

On Spiritual Formation

with Special Regard to Our System of Upbringing.

Six Lectures

by

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Copenhagen.

Gyldendal's Bookshop, Publishers (F. Hegel & Son).

Printed by J. Jørgensen & Co.

1877.

Translated from the Danish

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First Lecture.

Great and considerable efforts are being made in our day for the benefit of enlightenment and formation. Alongside learned formation and the manifold kinds of professional formation, weight is laid on general formation: political, aesthetic, social formation. Everyone in society takes pride in counting as a cultivated person. It is with formation as with dress. Formation is a becoming adornment; who does not wish to be well dressed and to show himself to advantage? [1]

But despite the commendable zeal for the many-sidedness of formation, it might well appear, if we look more closely, that something has been forgotten, that the much-praised many-sidedness is in a high degree one-sided. What the enlightened of the present age understand by formation is as good as exclusively a formation in relation to *the manifold*; it is what we will call, in one word, *cultural formation*. That there must also be a formation in relation to the simple, and that this is the proper *spiritual formation*, is, so far as we can see, all too lightly overlooked. It is assumed without further ado that cultural formation is all in all, so that when one only has culture in ample measure, spiritual formation follows of itself; that is a dubious error.

Cultural formation turns its gaze outward; whatever glides past the searching eye in the world of multiplicity is transformed into phenomenon. Thought, the supersensible, is phenomenon just as much as the sensible; conscience is phenomenon just as much as electricity, genius a phenomenon as much as lightning, Christ a phenomenon as Buddha and Mohammed are. If we now call the human being whose whole content of consciousness empties itself out into the forms of cultural formation a man of culture, it is easy to understand that such a man, however busy he may be with things and with himself, can never become so turned inward that he in earnest catches sight of the essence either of things or of himself. He by no means denies that there is essence in things, but, he says, this essence in and for itself cannot be known. He does not deny that in a way he does have a soul, but what sort of being the soul is, and whether it really is a being—how should he be able to know that? If he will contemplate his soul in order thereby to discover his own self, then this self instantly becomes a phenomenon to him. And what, then, lies at the ground of this phenomenon? Something mystical, over which one should not brood. Indifferent to what he is in himself, he then cultivates himself so as to seem something, to be seen and to cut a figure as a considerable phenomenon in the series of phenomena. [2]

Turned outward toward the manifold, the cultural consciousness is many-sided; it is like an Argus studded with eyes, a hundred clear eyes; but these hundred clear eyes all lie under the spell that whatever they fasten upon instantly hides its essence and turns into mere phenomenon. But one cannot immerse oneself in a phenomenon [3] that keeps its essence hidden, and that in which one cannot immerse oneself has only a fleeting, passing interest. One grows tired of familiar phenomena, as the child of its toys, and craves something new. No single phenomenon has validity in and for itself; only the alternation of phenomena, their play of colors, and their connection in large groups have interest. Once one is finished with them at home, one must be off and look about abroad. The man of culture is a cosmopolitan, an Odysseus, widely traveled; he speaks many languages, has been in many lands, has lived with Cyclopes and nymphs alike. How enlivening it is to hear him speak of the mountains he has climbed, the museums he has visited, the excavations of priceless treasures of antiquity at which he himself was present. He can criticize authors, for he knows the literatures; he can describe buildings and monuments, for he knows the styles; paintings and statues!—yes, he has a connoisseur’s eye, he has taste.

But what does the man of culture know in relation to the simple? What a question! If simplicity is a phenomenon like everything else in the world, should the cultivated man not know that besides stupidity there are higher kinds of simplicity: in the innocence of the child, in the virginal soul of woman, in the artist’s naivety of genius, in the faith of the common people, in religion? Yes indeed, he says, holy simplicity is noble and beautiful; but criticism is the flower of formation, the consummation of culture; criticism, “the tenth Muse,” stands to simplicity as the falcon to the dove; one poisonous sting of sharp criticism can kill faith, and with faith religion falls.

Spiritual formation turns its gaze inward, yet not so as to exclude the manifold. [4] In optics there are lenses of different shapes, some that scatter the rays, others that gather them. Cultural formation prefers ray-scattering lenses with an imaginary focal point; spiritual formation requires gatherers of rays and places them so that the focal point falls in the self. “Know thyself!”—theoretically, that means: fix your attention on your inner, supersensible being, for only in and through this being are you able to know phenomena. It is, after all, you yourself who see and hear, perceive and feel; it is you yourself who rejoice and grieve, think and ponder; it is you yourself who live. If you would know what life is, what the soul is, what consciousness is, then seek the answer above all in yourself. The stars of heaven, the animals of the earth and the atoms of the brain cannot give you the least contribution at first hand, for

what you know of these things you know only by virtue of your own consciousness; what you judge of these things you judge by virtue of your own understanding; what value you attach to these things you attach to them by virtue of your own feeling. Do not imagine that by starting from a critical consideration of the animal species in their multiplicity, or of the human race in general, you can discover what life is in its essence; critical consideration must have a standard, but whatever you discuss and whatever you measure, in the last instance you carry the standard within yourself. “Know thyself!”—practically, that means: hold fast to yourself, not in selfish conceit but in free, conscious interaction with the surrounding world. There is an order of things under which you must bow and by which you must let yourself be determined. It prescribes conditions to you, but you can choose; it offers you enjoyments, it lays sufferings upon you, it threatens you with death; but how you understand all [5] this depends on your composure of mind and your self-understanding; how you conduct yourself in all this depends on the direction of your will, and so, essentially, on how you yourself are.—From dispersion in the external, from the multiplicity of phenomena, spiritual formation would lead the human being back to the simple One, the essential inner being in which the self lives, and then through this inner being to the source of all life, the author of nature, to the riddle of necessity, to the wellspring of freedom, to spirit as spirit, to God.

Without spiritual formation no coherent world-view, cast in one piece, is possible; without a coherent world-view no true independence of character is possible. An inwardly free and independent character can no more be acquired by sailing with every current and keeping a lookout for every curiosity than by shutting one’s eye to the actual and, like a navel-gazer, staring at the mystical point in the soul. What we call, in the essential sense, a world-view, a view of life, rests on a reciprocal determination of what comes from without by what is originally in ourselves and comes from within—a reciprocal determination so thoroughgoing that the soul, amid all the impressions from the world of things and phenomena, preserves the impression of itself. The self must show itself as a co-determining, fundamentally determining factor, not merely as the collector and bearer of the whole. The essence of this many-sided reciprocal determination, rooted in self-determination, is spirit.

Spiritual formation is not attained by accepting on external authority the fixed dogmas of a positive religious doctrine. There are many who have plenty of positive [6] dogmas about spirit, and yet they have no spiritual formation; whereas a “free thinker,” who denies all dogmas, can have spiritual formation. As regards the negative and

the positive in spiritual formation, it depends essentially on how the denial and the acceptance are grounded. If someone, e.g., will deny the existence of God and the immortality of the soul because he imagines that sufficient, irrefutable proofs of the unreasonableness of accepting them have been given in natural science and criticism, then he is blind and stupid in relation to spirit. If, on the other hand, he is in a position to understand himself and to carry his life through consistently in denial; if he finds that there is something in his being that rebels against God as well as against eternal life; if he denies because he is clearly conscious that, by the constitution of his mind, he will deny and must deny: then his denial bears the stamp of originality; he has spirit in negative form, he has spiritual formation. A denier of spirit who has spirit can be an instrument of spirit, an able taskmaster for a generation that is spiritually enfeebled, spiritually unclear, spiritually lazy, spiritually befooled.

Positive spiritual formation can go in different directions, according as one stands toward the two ideal powers: *necessity and freedom*. If necessity is posited as the original and freedom as the derived, formation will go in a rational direction, and conviction will be grounded on knowledge. If freedom is posited as the original and necessity as the derived, formation will go in a religious direction, and conviction will be built on faith. In the first case the emphasis falls on the cognition of the eternal reason that expresses itself in nature; the human being grasps and understands himself [7] as a rational being in a world of rational, necessary laws. In the second case the emphasis falls on the cognition of God and the word of life that reveals his will. The human being grasps and understands himself as an “image of God,” an organ of will for the divine spirit.

But in whichever of these two main directions spiritual formation goes, the cognition of the world must still allow itself to be reconciled with the cognition of God, and the view of life must be coherent in both respects. From this standpoint it can best be seen how matters stand with the many-sided formation of the nineteenth century, namely by casting a glance at our educational system.

In the doctrine of reason one has got no further than a critical dissolution of the dogmas of positive religion, and in the doctrine of religion no further than a simple repetition and modified inculcation of the old dogmas. If upbringing were to be built on a view of life in which there really was unity and coherence, one would have to have, at least for the time being, two separate institutions of upbringing, two kinds of school: a *culture-school* on the foundation of reason and a *church-school* on the foundation of positive religion, so that there really would be two views of life to

choose between.

In the church-school everything would then have to be strictly kept away that could mediatly or immediately weaken faith in the historical infallibility of the religious tradition and awaken doubt about the absolute truth of the dogmas. The whole of upbringing would have to be arranged accordingly. The church-school could then not confine itself to instruction in religion alone; it would have to give, in its own way, a real cognition of nature and the world, normative for culture and science. The pupils in such a school might well learn languages, both ancient and modern; but [8] for the origin of the many languages they must know no other explanation than the building of the tower of Babel. That history must be taught, both Bible history and general world history, goes without saying; but the decisive thing is that the course of history and the great events be kept constantly in the light of Paradise and the Fall and the devil's continued struggle against governing Providence. Nor is there then anything to prevent mathematics, physics and natural history from being taught as well; but it must count as an unshakable presupposition that the world was created in six days, that heaven is a fixed vault, and that the earth stands still while the sun rises and sets. Hypotheses about animal species that are supposed to have died out before the appearance of man, about a natural state of savagery without a preceding Paradise, and the like, must be treated as "the rudiments of the world," fantasies of an unbaptized reason; for it is surely clear that no animal could die before death had come into the world, and death came, after all, only after man had sinned. In this way unity comes into instruction. Man knows how he was created, how he has fallen, and how he can be raised up again: on this foundation an upbringing can be carried through, and spiritual formation will be accordingly.

In the culture-school the ground must be cleared and the premises cleansed of all manner of musty traditions. Criticism, with "free thought," should see to it that the place is properly aired, so that one can breathe freely in the atmosphere of reason. In place of the dogmas of theology the great principles of natural science are set up: the eternity of matter, the immutability of the laws of nature. Astronomy's teaching about the globes in space, geology's account of the periods of the earth, zoology's [9] conception of the descent of the human race, the general presupposition of nature as the absolutely necessary, self-sufficient ground of everything, spirit included: these cognitions of reason furnish the elements of the foundation on which the view of life is to rest and upbringing is to be laid out. A moral teaching is necessary; but the moral commandments must be conceived as general commandments of reason,

whose fulfillment is demanded by society, but whose application within the limits of the coercive laws receives freedom and freshness, color and life, from the peculiar natural ground of the self-conscious individuality. Religion can be taught just as well as cultural history and languages, but the whole development falls under the viewpoint of the necessity of reason; it goes without saying that the positive religions, with their miracles and supernatural phenomena, are without exception conceived as mythologies. Add to this a demonstration of the ideal in art and poetry, an acknowledgment of the nobler feelings of the human heart, of the right of conscience and of the free personality: and one surely has a coherent world-view on which a system of upbringing can be carried through consistently. Spiritual formation will be accordingly.

Let it be well noted that the two systems of upbringing are so worlds apart in spirit and direction that any principle borrowed from the one and taken up into the other must necessarily confuse the mind and weaken the character. Now, has one hitherto kept the two schools apart from each other? No. Is it likely that one will be able to [10] keep them apart in the future? No. What, then, has one done, and what will one go on doing? Mix them together in total unclarity. From the common school right up to the university the mixture is continued, in our critical present age, in a most uncritical manner. One thinks thus: a cultivated person must know the rational order of the world, and a cultivated person ought to know the chief doctrines of religion. Rational cognition guides us in our undertakings; religion strengthens our moral feeling and comforts us in our sufferings. Society can do no more for the young generation than open to it access to many-sided formation; the relation between reason and positive religion is a riddle that each must solve for himself as well as he can.

But is it now also defensible to fill young souls with a hodgepodge of conflicting notions and to ground their upbringing on a sum of dark riddles that one neither can nor cares to solve oneself? Let religion have its mysteries and nature its own; it is nonetheless an inescapable demand that those who are to be the teachers of youth must be able to give an account of how matters stand with our cognition of the supernatural in religion and with our rational cognition of the world. If they cannot, then humane upbringing in the present age, as regards the formation of character, must come to stand far below the Catholic upbringing of the Middle Ages and the Greek and Roman upbringing of antiquity.

Imagine among us a father's address to his son when the son, his instruction completed, leaves school. "My son! You now know the two guiding stars that are to

shine upon your way, religion and reason. Never lose sight of them! They seldom shine equally brightly at the same time, but when the one goes out, the other is lit, so [11] you will never be without guidance. The one sits high in the supernatural heaven and gives you hints of an almighty will which, when it will, can shake the earth and make the stars fall; the other shines in the infinite space of nature and makes clear to you a world order so unchangeable that not even the least speck can be moved in it without a natural cause. The one rises in the east, the other in the west. By following the first you are taught that the earth is under a curse, and that the way to the goal is the way of sufferings to blessedness in the world beyond; by following the second you know that nature is good as it is, and this world an arena for a rich development of your gifts and powers. Religion has taught you that before God you are a guilty sinner, eternally lost if you cannot be pardoned through another's merit and intercession. Reason has let you see that you must yourself atone for your transgressions, that no substitute and no arbitrary grace can help you out of the contradictions of life in which you have entangled yourself. So I know that you have been many-sidedly instructed. Steer your course now by the guiding stars! With your double compass you can safely plow the sea of life and expect to reach a quiet harbor."

Such an address will sound like a parody of our whole educational system; and yet it is so free of all exaggeration that the contradictions indicated become far more glaring when one goes into particulars. But it is one thing to mix the irreconcilable, another to combine what essentially belongs together. If one grants that a religious cognition of God is just as necessary to man as a rational cognition of the world, and that spiritual formation is conditioned by the union of the two, then the world of [12] culture has a great task to solve with regard to its system of upbringing.

In the teaching of the special scientific disciplines there is nothing in this respect to correct. The choice of material and method depends on the purpose and on particular conditions. Everything depends on the application that the results of science find in the doctrine of spirit. We choose as an example *creation*. Is this world created, or is its nature, with absolute necessity, what it is from eternity? To judge by the haste with which modern criticism has decked out positive religion as a sacrificial victim on the altar of naturalism, one would certainly suppose that creation was a sham dogma, a blind notion without rational meaning. But is it really so? Natural science starts from the principle that there is reason in nature. That is more than a hypothesis, for if the opposite is assumed, science is impossible. If someone should perhaps assert that reason and nature are one and the same, so that the expression "there is reason in

nature” says nothing other than that there is reason in reason, nature in nature, then such an assertion does not exactly betray an excessive measure of critical acumen. If there is to be rational meaning in the expression, it must necessarily be understood that the unity of reason and nature includes an essential difference. If we will now stop for a moment and reflect on what is then properly to be understood by reason, might not logical necessity lead us to spirit?

“*The laws of nature*,” says H. C. Ørsted, “together with what is active, constitute the [13] *universal* in multiplicity and the eternal in change. The laws of nature can therefore also be called *thoughts of nature*. But just as in all thinking there is an activity, and the thought, thought without it, is only a form of thinking, so in every existing thing there is an activity by which it asserts its existence and expresses it against other things. Without activity it has no actuality. In thinking we call this active element will, in external objects force. But just as willing and thinking are one, only regarded from two sides, so too are force and natural law; they are expressions of an infinite unity of force and thought, of divine willing and divine *thinking*... What we know in nature is thus nothing foreign, but the same as what lives in ourselves.”—If, then, from “what lives in ourselves” we are to be able to see what divine thinking and willing mean, it must surely become clear to us that, even if we cannot possibly picture the Godhead to ourselves as a thinking and willing individual in human fashion, we must nevertheless necessarily conceive it as a thinking, willing self-being, i.e., as a rational being distinct from nature. An eternal thinking without an eternal thinker, an eternal willing without an eternal willer, thoughts that no one has thought, determinations of will that no one has willed—such assumptions belong in the world of fancies. Nature can no more think the thoughts that express themselves in its laws than it can will the “actions” by which these laws are fulfilled. Every thing acts according to its nature; but what is a thing’s nature other than its inner disposition, determined by divine [14] thinking and willing? Since no natural thing can give itself a disposition, the rational disposition of nature must originally be determined by the all-determining self-being, i.e., by the all-knowing, all-powerful spirit. Through the cognition of things and their laws we are led to the cognition of a rational world order; through the cognition of a given world order to the cognition of the ordering reason; but the ordering reason is a fancy if it does not have spirit as its ground and bearer.

With the same right as we say “there is reason in nature,” we can also say “there is reason in spirit.” Spirit and reason are one, but in such a way that this unity includes a difference. When we speak of reason, we think first and foremost of the infinite

content of thoughts of wisdom, determinations of will, concepts and laws that is realized in nature by virtue of the dispositions of things. When we speak of spirit, we think of the infinite self-being which, thinking, willing, producing, unfolds the content of reason from its inner depth. From this standpoint the relation between necessity and freedom, nature and creation, can be cleared up. Necessity is seen in nature in so far as it reveals itself in the rational connection of things: the consequent must necessarily have its ground, the effect its cause. To assume an arbitrary will which, without natural causes, could take it into its head to produce or annihilate natural things, or to make natural things unnatural, is certainly a sign of dreaming and superstition.

“It has indeed also been attempted,” says Ørsted, “to defend the dreams of superstition against natural science by pointing out that an immeasurably greater part of nature is more unknown to us than well known. This defense can, even among [15] the uninitiated, show nothing but a possibility, which must nonetheless be all the less significant the more of the old superstition’s fancies have been so illuminated that their nothingness has been settled; but for those who have not been content to appropriate natural science with memory and understanding, but have lived their way into its whole, it is clear that our insights, despite all their imperfections, nevertheless annihilate every thought that anything contrary to reason should take place in nature.” We must unconditionally endorse this statement.

Within the given whole, things and laws must necessarily correspond to each other: other forces, other laws; other laws, other forces. But is the absolute necessity of the given whole thereby proved? By no means! To assume that the given world of experience must be the only possible world because every breach of its laws is contrary to reason is just as unreasonable as to assume that the right-angled triangle is the only possible triangle because the denial of the Pythagorean theorem is contrary to reason. The given nature is certainly a rational whole, but the peculiar character of this whole is determined by its peculiar disposition, originally determined by an almighty self-determination of spirit as spirit, and so by a *creation*.

If, now, from the standpoint of the doctrine of reason the prospect has been opened that the rational cognition of the world can be united with a religious cognition of God, then it must surely also be possible to show, from the standpoint of the doctrine of religion, that the religious cognition of God is compatible with a rational cognition of the world. But on what conditions? Here there is something that must be changed, remolded, reworked from the ground up. What is it? Surely not revealed religion, its [16]

supernatural origin, its miracles and holy facts? Far from it! Rationalism, the new as well as the old, has prostituted itself more than enough in this respect. It is not the world-view of revelation, as it stands before us with all the marks of antiquity, whose features of character are to be effaced. No, it is something quite different that must be demanded for the sake of upbringing and spiritual formation. It is our inner, essential relation to what has been revealed, our understanding, our personal appropriation of it—in short, our whole religious consciousness, our faith—that must be reworked from the ground up. What such a reworking means, where it leads, and how far it can be carried through, will be the subject of closer consideration in what follows.

Second Lecture.

Religion is the foundation of the life of the spirit; religion must be grasped in faith. [17]
It is then natural to make a person's faith the measure of his spirit: the stronger the faith, the more vigorous the spirit; the more vigorous the spirit, the stronger the faith. Yet this is not always so. True, there can be no true and fruitful development of the spirit without faith; but there can in actuality be an obstinate, strong and unshakable faith that is nonetheless very poor in spirit, and indeed incapable of grounding any real spiritual formation.

For faith has two main sides, just as positive religion has two main sides: an external and an internal, a sensible and a supersensible, a historical in its tradition and a suprahistorical in its essence. In the beginning the two elements are fused together: the internal comes to light in something external, and the external converts itself immediately into something internal; but gradually they separate, and dangerous crises set in in the life of the spirit.

It is a characteristic mark of all positive religions without exception that at their first appearance they announce themselves as divine revelations. The less spirit there is in such a revelation, the more emphasis is laid on the acceptance of the external. [18]
The orthodox Mohammedan assumes that the Koran has existed from eternity in the highest heaven on the so-called Preserved Tablet, and that from there it was revealed piecemeal to Mohammed by the angel Gabriel over a period of 23 years. The contradictions found in the holy book are resolved by the interpreters in such a way that the verse revealed later abrogates the earlier one. Here is a firm, unshakable faith in something external. Judaism, too, lays decisive weight on what has externally happened and what is externally prescribed; but, as telling proof that there is originally more spirit in the faith in Jehovah than in Mohammedanism, the prophets stood up against the ceremonies of the priests and the external commandments, and in the name of the spirit made the internal prevail. In Christianity, the absolute religion of the spirit, the external must serve the internal. Christ says: "my words are spirit and are life."—"I am the truth."—"You shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free."—If one gives up the positive, historical foothold, inwardness becomes mystical, and the religious consciousness hovers in the air; but if, conversely, one places the assurance of faith in the sensible experience of a supernatural external, then the Mohammedan faith stands, in life and vigor and in glowing colors, on the highest

step.

In the history of the Crusades wonderful things are told of a wonderful figure in the East, “the *Old Man of the Mountain*.” Hassan-ben-Sabbah, head of the “Brotherhood of the Ismailites,” had known how to instill in his subjects so unconditional a faith in the words of the Koran, so punctual an obedience to its commandments, and thereby [19] so blind a submission to his own holy authority, that he astonished the world. His faithful despised worldly honor, suffering and torments, indeed life itself, in order to obey his slightest sign. That was upbringing. A Count Henry of Champagne traveled through the land of the Ismailites, visited the Old Man in his castle, and received an honorable welcome. On each of the high towers two men stood on guard, rigid as pillars. Hassan gave a sign to a couple of these sentries, and instantly they hurled themselves from the tower and lay shattered at the feet of the astonished crusader. The Old Man remarked in cold blood: “Should you wish it, you would see them all hurl themselves to the ground like that at my sign.”

With this unconditional faith, this blind obedience, there was, according to the accounts, a peculiar connection. So far were the men on guard on the towers from facing such a moment with horror, or regarding the Old Man as a cruel tyrant obeyed only out of fear, that on the contrary they honored him in the inmost depths of their souls and regarded a relief from duty such as the one described above as the happiest of all. The closer circumstances are presented thus. The sect of the Ismailites was originally divided into two classes, masters and apprentices; to these Hassan added a third class, which was to be ignorant of the sect’s real secrets. The members of this class were called the Victims; they were dressed in white, with red caps and sashes, and had to keep constantly about the Grand Master in order to defend and avenge him. In the midst of the lands over which the Old Man ruled lay a castle, a paradise of Mohammed on earth. Lovely gardens, leafy trees, flowers bedewed by the spray of [20] fountains bade the one who entered welcome; shady walks shielded him from the burning of the sun. The dwelling within shone with gold and marble; arabesques, silks and costly carpets in the high, cool halls, young girls resting on soft divans in voluptuous luxury!—here was everything a believing soul could wish and desire. Now when a youth was to be initiated for admission to the class of the Victims (the Fedawi), it was done in the following manner. In the Old Man’s presence he was stupefied by a drink prepared from hashish (the leaves of Indian hemp), and in this unconscious state he was carried to the enchanting place. When he then opened his eyes, he could not but believe that he was in Paradise, and enjoyed in full measure all

the joys of blessedness. He was then stupefied again and brought back. The Old Man stood once more at his side and assured him, now awake, that he had not bodily been away from the spot; if, notwithstanding, it was as he said, then his soul must by a miracle have been caught up into Paradise. So the young man had faith in his hands; in melancholy he longed for the hour when he should enter there for all eternity, and he was willing to submit in unconditional obedience to the conditions that the holy authority prescribed for him.

Even within the religion of the spirit there is something Mohammedan in the faith of the church, especially the Catholic church. What we here understand by the Mohammedan element does not lie in the first instance in the teaching, in the dogmas, in the precepts, in the ceremonies, not in what is the object of faith, but originally in faith itself, in the way in which faith is conceived and determined. If one should perhaps object that the way in which the essence of faith is conceived and determined is itself a dogma, then one is merely moving in a circle. One cannot possibly prescribe faith in the dogma of faith without presupposing a personal inner [21] being, a conscience, that can believe itself obliged to accept the dogma. However much persuasion or coercion one employs, the acceptance cannot become faith unless there is something in the soul itself that says Yes and Amen to the dogma of faith. Faith is therefore, in the first instance, an original expression of freedom, an act of self-determination, a recognition of truth on personal grounds. In what, then, does the Mohammedan element consist? Simply in this: that the personal impression of the object of faith, which should form the starting point for an appropriation in spirit and in truth, is all at once transformed into a motive for unconditional submission to an external authority. "You must surely feel within yourself and recognize that you are a fallen, helpless creature in need of restoration and salvation": when this appeal to the conscience of man has had its effect, then follows the summons: "seize the salvation that is offered, as the shipwrecked man seizes the plank of rescue; let yourself be received into the bosom of the one Church that saves!" Now it is all over with self-understanding and free appropriation. Faith in the Church, blind submission to its authority, unconditional obedience to its commandments is the condition of salvation. To be sure, the Church does not neglect to inform its faithful of what it is they are to believe. It teaches them what God is, what holiness is, what sin is; all this can be clearly understood down to the last detail. But from all this understanding there is one thing essentially excluded, and that is self-understanding. It is the Church's God, the Church's holiness, that is believed in. The believer does not know at all what

God is in himself; he knows only what the Church teaches that God is. He does not
 [22] even know what sin is and what it is to sin; the Church must literally teach him that. What the Church stamps as sin is sin, even if natural feeling says the opposite; when the Church has blotted out a sin, then it is blotted out, however much the original sense of right and wrong may have to object. The secret is that the believer has no conscience of his own, that he has given the Church his conscience. Faith in authority is externality in the internal; the formula of this externality is the dogma.

The alarm has been sounded against the Catholic Church's many historical encroachments in external matters; and it is true, they have been outrageous, and may perhaps yet, when "the modern consciousness" has properly helped along and done its best, become outrageous enough; but these are the ordinary encroachments of the wielders of power, which are met and halted with external weapons. The radical encroachment, the one that devours the spirit, is the transformation of the internal itself into something external. This Mohammedan element—that faith in authority takes the inner man captive, lures him out of himself, makes him a stranger to himself, so that, stupefied as by a magic potion, fantastically and yet with understanding, he can find blessedness outside himself and thereby attain a kind of sensible assurance of its reality—is a beguiling illusion, an insurmountable barrier to spiritual formation.

Much outcry has been raised over the many arbitrary additions in the Catholic tradition, its invented miracles, its legends and superstition; not without reason. The miracles are its supernatural building materials, its ornaments; the legends twine like ivy up its walls: it is luxuriously furnished with the inventions of superstition. And yet the objects of superstition are not yet the essence of superstition, but only its
 [23] outgrowths. Superstition sits in the sanctuary, in faith itself as faith in authority.

For all that, there is spirit in the Catholic way of being. On the foundation of authority and blind obedience the Jesuits have shown what can be attained by mystically compressed inwardness and a consistent system of upbringing. A character like Francis Xavier one will seek in vain in any other church communion. Such courage of faith, such perseverance in renunciation and self-denial, such concern to win souls, must, in the eyes of those who look one-sidedly at the external, place this Jesuit missionary on a level with the apostle Paul. But according to his inner being, what is he then? An incarnation of that faith in authority which robs the personal self of its power from the ground up. It is not his own human being that has come to development under the influence of the Church; on the contrary, it is the being of the Church that has forced its way into him from without. The Church has taken his

heart, his will, out of his breast and set its own heart, its spirit, its will in their place. He believes the Church's faith in the Church's name; his renunciation of the world is in him the Church's renunciation, his zeal for conversion the Church's zeal; he himself is the blind instrument, "will-less as a corpse," obedient "as the staff in an old man's hand." What he does is certainly something far higher and better than what those men did who hurled themselves down from the tower, because what his authority has prescribed to him is higher and better; but the motive is the same: unconditional obedience, blind submission to an external authority.

Through its faith in authority and its system of upbringing the Catholic Church has set an eternal enmity between itself and human reason. It may indeed seem as if [24] the systematic development and grounding of the Church's body of doctrine contained an essential acknowledgment of the right of reason; but the acknowledgment is only a semblance. Certainly there have been, and still are, great men of science, famous scholars, not only historians and philologists but also mathematicians, astronomers, physicists, and even philosophers, in the bosom of the Church. But if we look more closely, the sciences that move in a worldly domain are only tolerated to a certain degree. The Church can, as circumstances dictate, close an eye to scientific theories and hypotheses so long as they do not openly set themselves against its authority; but this always happens on the tacit presupposition that its own infallible knowledge is infinitely exalted above "the rudiments of this world." As regards thinking in relation to dogma, the dependence of reason is downright slavish. Reason is obliged to concede that Christ has two wills because the Church says he has two; if the Church said he had two and a half wills, then reason would not only be compelled to accept it as truth, but would even have to do its best to get it proved. That the bread which, before it is consecrated by the priest, is natural bread can after the consecration keep its natural taste, its natural appearance and its natural properties, and yet no longer be natural bread, but be transformed into the body with which Christ was crucified—this is so mighty a blow in the face of reason that everything must go black before its eyes and convince it that the Catholic faith in authority is just as incompatible with a rational cognition of the world as the revelations of the Koran.

With the Reformation the dogma of faith began to undergo an essential transfor- [25] mation. Luther broke with the Catholic authority, asserted the right of conscience, and conceived faith as the personal appropriation of the merit of Christ, and so as the fundamental factor in the inwardness of the religious life. For a moment it looked as though the outer was to be reduced all at once to stuff and material for the inner as

it worked its way forward, and the holy words of Scripture, glowing through with spirit, kindled the light of self-understanding in the soul. But it was not long before the object of faith drew attention away from the movements in the believing self. The strong religious life became little by little a doctrine about life. The Protestant Church got its own theology and its own dogmatics in the likeness of the Catholic: externality celebrated a new triumph when the Church became a state church and orthodoxy went so far as to have its dogmas registered, like deeds, by the police authority. Under royal custody, faith in authority had now taken up residence in Scripture, essentially just as external as formerly in the papacy.

The assertion that something is true because it stands in the Bible is just as Mohammedan as that something is true because it stands in the Koran. Orthodox faith in the Bible can no more catch sight of the circle in which it moves than orthodox faith in the pope. He who believes in the infallibility of the Church imagines that, freed from all human fallibility, he has the infallible over against him, and does not notice that it is he himself who adds the infallibility out of his own. He believes in the Church because it is infallible, and behold, then it is only his own faith in its infallibility that is infallible. Likewise with him who builds his faith externally on [26] Scripture. He would not know at all what he was to believe if the infallible Scripture did not teach it to him; but neither does he know that it is his own—infallible!—faith that teaches him that Scripture is infallible. So on both sides one appeals to the testimony of the spirit; but with faith in authority one gets only the dogma about the spirit, not the spirit itself, only the dogma about the testimony, not the testimony itself. In the personal testimony of the spirit the divine must be confirmed by the human just as fully as the human by the divine.

It is a fact that Lutheran orthodoxy, held fast in its positive dogmas, stands in the same hostile relation to the culture and science of the present age as the Catholic. It is not only in the physical and the historical, but even in the psychological, in the life of consciousness, that the obstacles to a mutual understanding show themselves. Think of the doctrine of the absolute corruption of human nature through original sin, of God's universal grace, which is nevertheless not universal but benefits only the elect; of the doctrine of the two natures in Christ, of his seat at the right hand of the Father, of the omnipresence of his body and yet its limited presence in the Lord's Supper, etc.; and one will soon discover, without overtaxing one's understanding, that even if many, many have believed literally in all this, there is nevertheless no one who has believed it in spirit and in truth, for the simple reason that no one has been

able to believe it. To believe in something is to have it in the form of dogma as the object of faith; but to believe something is, by inward appropriation, to transform it into the content of faith. As regards objects of faith, there can hardly be anything shown so unreasonable and absurd that it cannot, from one side or another, become the object of a faith in authority: the absurd is, after all, precisely that which can be [27] accepted only on authority. It is otherwise with the content of faith. What is to be inwardly taken up into the religious consciousness as spiritual nourishment for the soul must, like every other nourishment, let itself be dissolved and digested; it must assimilate itself to the essence of consciousness: the understanding of it must become one with a personal self-understanding. The positive dogmas, be they for the rest knotty and angular or round and polished, are in their fixed state like stones, clear crystals, perhaps precious stones!—but not the bread of life. One can hang them on the outside of consciousness and adorn one's soul with them; but one cannot digest them.

The relation between the school of reason and the church-school appears in a new light when faith is conceived as the personal appropriation of the universally religious content of the positive dogmas. It is by no means the task to abolish the faith of the church, or in any external sense whatsoever to attack authority as authority. On the contrary! In external relations authority can be not only venerable but even necessary. Not even rational instruction can do without authority. The disciple must accept definite propositions on the teacher's authority, and, trusting that what still lies above his understanding will become intelligible to him, work his way forward to insight. The coat of arms of authority ought to stand over the entrance to the school of inquiry. A science that has not yet won esteem in public opinion, and thereby a certain authority, will be exposed to the most superficial objections without anyone troubling to look into the matter. If it goes thus with the rational, which must after all be able to assert itself by virtue of universally valid proofs, how must it not go with [28] the religious, which can be recognized only on personal grounds? If the word of the Bible has no authority, the Church and its dogmas no venerability, no esteem, then religion is abandoned, and anyone can mock it according to whim and fancy. The truth itself, the eternal truth, which is before Abraham was, had, after all, to put on flesh and blood and step forth before men in human form as authority.

But even the absolutely true authority is only something external; the truth, the eternal being, is something internal; the truth demands recognition, and for the sake of recognition it reduces the external to a means and gives its authority over

to dissolution. "You shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free." That authority is dissolved does not, then, mean that it is abolished; no, it means that it is in truth confirmed. Only the false authority is finished when it is dissolved. A false authority, theology for example, must be weakened the more, the more its scientific character is tested, for every attempt to know its grounds dissolves into the absurd. Perhaps it will be objected that when theology loses its authority, the Church and the dogmas must suffer for it. That would be true if the authority of the Church were built on theology; the rational thaw that dissolves the last remnants of theological authority would then certainly draw the dissolution of the Church's authority after it. But the authority of the Church, when we think about it, is built not on theology but on religion; it is an authority not for science but for faith, an authority of faith. Whether this authority of faith is true or false depends on whether its dogmas, through [29] religious, personal appropriation, dissolve into truth or into untruth. Here is a task for spiritual formation, a fundamental problem for a religious-rational upbringing. Some examples.

Nature and creation. "In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth": these words of the Bible, with the story of creation that follows them, have the authority of the Church. "Nature is uncreated; all formations in heaven and on earth have come about naturally": this assertion has, according to the naturalistic way of seeing, scientific authority. Can an unconditional faith in either of these two authorities now take the place of the recognition of truth? Impossible! If one lets the authority of the Church exclude that of science, one can easily get free of all trouble with what is rational. One lays one's head to rest on the lazy pillow of authority, reason dozes off, and reason, gently dozed off, is not easily disturbed by the noiseless tread of rational knowledge. One dreams of the miracle of creation and Adam in Paradise; but such dreamings do not lead to a personal recognition of truth in faith. If one lets the authority of science exclude that of the Church, one undeniably has a spur to rational inquiry into everything given in its connection; but whence the connection and the connected are remains a riddle, for personal self-knowledge is lacking. If religion has no authority, one is all too quickly finished with freedom in the question of the origin of things. Nature is necessity and necessity nature; natural necessity swallows up freedom, first the divine and then the human. If science has no authority, one is all too quickly finished with nature. The Creator is almighty and can do everything he will [30] with created nature; man's freedom is not essentially dependent on the laws of nature but on the free will of the Creator: the whole dissolves into divine arbitrariness. Only

the united pressure of both authorities can set all the wheels of inquiry in motion and drive the life of consciousness forward from the cognition of God to the cognition of the world, from the religious to the rational, from faith to knowledge and from knowledge to faith.

Sin and redemption. Religion, with the authority of the Church, will vouch that sin is the ruin of nations, that sinful man cannot by his own strength rise from his fall, but needs a divine helper and redeemer. Reason, with the authority of science, will vouch that universal sinfulness is a simple paraphrase of the necessary imperfection of human nature, that the conditions of liberation must be sought in the perfectibility of this nature, that the human race, by a rational use of its natural powers, can and must in the course of time little by little become its own savior. If one now throws the authority of reason overboard, what then? Then the dogmatic notion of sin and corruption grows to such a height that it darkens the whole of existence and ends by making religious self-knowledge impossible. No light of faith is able to illuminate the abyss of corruption. If we conceive faith not as a faith in dogma, a blind faith in authority, but as a personal appropriation, grounded in self-understanding, of the revealed word, then there is surely no one who can or could believe that human nature has been so corrupted at the root by Adam's sin that the individuals of the race are without exception forfeit to eternal damnation. If one rejects the authority of the Church and of dogma, then not only does original sin become a perverse [31] fancy, but even actual sins find so many excuses in the drives of natural necessity that sin and guilt become empty phrases, and the consciousness of sin a sign of effeminate voluptuousness. Among the spokesmen of culture there may even occur such superficial, indeed such brutal, scoffing remarks about sin and guilt that moral accountability is wiped out. Why? Because one does not find it worth the trouble to go into oneself and examine the consciousness of sin more closely.—Both authorities, the Church and science, are indispensable if man, through the inner co-operation of faith and reason, is to discover the secret of sin and redemption and have his personal being cleared up.

The eternal life. We have the authority of Scripture and of the Church for the claim that the existence of an eternal life is historically established by the resurrection of Christ. We have the scientific authority of natural science for the claim that the story of the resurrection is in conflict with the laws of nature. Now if the authority of the Church is to hold exclusively, then the assurance of eternal life is built on the story of the resurrection, whose authority is built on the Bible, whose authority is

built on the authority of the Church, which in turn is built on the authority of history. That is a Mohammedan assurance by virtue of something external. If the authority of knowledge is to hold without further ado, then the story falls, together with the dogma, to criticism, and the result is that it is not life but the idea of life that is the eternal. In both cases one seeks certainty about the self outside the self, on the Church's side in a history, on the side of science in a contemplation of nature: the personal [32] understanding of personal life is excluded. The scientific earnestness with which the organic conditions of the soul's existence are investigated must correspond to the earnestness of faith with which religious inwardness embraces the consummation of personal life, and vice versa. The inquiry of reason is not to be restricted or adjusted in a finite manner to the religious, any more than the inquiry of faith is to be limited and accommodated to the rational. The dissolution must be complete from both starting points. Only when both authorities are dissolved, and the dissolution shows that the religious is precisely the possibility of the rational, and the rational the possibility of the religious, and that the unity of both possibilities is the original self-unity of personal life, destined for eternity—only then can faith be united with knowledge, religion with science.

As the only way out for reconciling the cultural consciousness with the religious need, people have begun to call back to life the rationalism that fell asleep more than a generation ago, by breathing the spirit of the age into it. But the attempt will hardly succeed. The rationalist is right when he demands that the dogmas of orthodoxy must be dissolved, but he is wrong to dissolve them into knowledge and not into faith; to dissolve them into knowledge is to crack them like hollow nuts: the religious kernel is gone. The rationalist wants to have his articles of faith grounded in science and does not notice that he smuggles in something personal that science cannot ground. He presupposes a holy, righteous and loving God, and does not notice that he has thereby gone far beyond the limits of knowledge. Concepts such as God's righteousness, God's love, God's grace, mercy and the like are not concepts of knowledge but concepts of [33] personality, concepts of faith. The righteous God of love is a God of personality, a God of the heart, a God of conscience. The rationalist assumes that the doctrine of the soul's immortality is rational, at bottom scientific, and does not notice that he confuses what science cannot disprove with what it can prove.

Lack of insight into the relation between the personal and the impersonal, the religious and the rational, is lack of spiritual formation, lack of upbringing.

Third Lecture.

We know from daily life how easily dispute can arise over the relation between word [34] and meaning. One should not, as the saying goes, cling to words but look at the meaning; and yet the meaning has its hold in the word. One should, as it is put in a higher style, consider that the spirit gives life but the letter kills; but in judicial rulings and in legislative assemblies one must also consider that the spirit clings to the literal expression and would without it be homeless and unreliable. The dispute about word and meaning, spirit and letter, gains decisive influence in the Protestant Church on the interpretation of Holy Scripture. The dogmaticians of the 16th and 17th centuries held the spirit fast in the letter and maintained that God himself had dictated word for word to the holy authors what they should write. In this sense the word of Scripture was God's word: prophets, evangelists and apostles had been only "God's scribes," "God's pens." There cannot, then, be even the least error or discrepancy in the written document of revelation, whether as regards the historical facts or as regards the expression of the religious: Holy Scripture is in each and every thing literally and [35] absolutely infallible. How theology has since fared with the deification of the Bible and the absolute faith in its infallibility, we shall not dwell upon: we pass over the fatalities of the external and fix our attention on the psychic, the internal.

Without closer acquaintance with the criticism of the biblical writings and the Church's dogma of inspiration, anyone who combines with the general formation of the present age a religious need and reverence for the word of Scripture, and reads through the Old and New Testaments, will convince himself that the spirit of revelation does not let itself be caught in the letter. It stands written in the Second Book of Samuel (24:1): "The wrath of Jehovah again struck Israel; for he tempted David"; it stands written in the First Book of Chronicles (21:1): "Satan was Israel's adversary, and he tempted David to number Israel." The event is the same. If one now holds strictly to the letter, then one gets out of it that Jehovah and Satan are one and the same being. If one separates Jehovah from Satan, one has by that very act separated the spirit from the letter, the meaning from the word, and applied an interpretation. It stands written in the prophet Hosea (11:1): "Israel was still young when I came to love him; out of Egypt I called my son." It stands written in Matthew (2:15) that the flight of Joseph with mother and child into Egypt took place "that it might be fulfilled which the Lord spoke by the prophet, who says: Out of Egypt I called

my son.” If this is to be understood literally, then the evangelist is in contradiction with the prophet, and the spirit in contradiction with itself. It is neither the same son nor the same event. The son of whom the prophet speaks is the Jewish people, which [36] in its youth was in Egyptian bondage. The prophet looks back on what is past, but the evangelist says that he looks forward to something to come. According to the letter, then, the spirit, when it literally speaks of the past, was literally speaking of what is to come. For the sake of the meaning it is necessary to apply an interpretation.

The interpretation cannot be infallible unless the reader can secure for himself an infallible interpreter. That the spirit in the word of Scripture is infallible benefits us only on condition that it can make our understanding of it infallible. If the reader of Scripture will now hold that the spirit stands in the very same relation to him as to the prophets and apostles, and tells him word for word what he is to believe and do, then his reading of Scripture is, in the religious sense, superfluous. If he must admit to himself that the spirit worked in the holy authors in a quite different way from the way it works in him, then a psychological barrier to understanding is thereby set up. The task is to determine the right relation between the original and the derived.

People complain of what is doubtful in the biblical narratives, of contradictions in the historical matter, etc.—all of it something subordinate. Even if all difficulties were removed, and the Bible from first to last in literal agreement with itself, it would still not help us in the very least, so long as the interaction between the divine and the human spirit remains inexplicable. The wonder of Pentecost is a telling example. If the outpouring of the spirit is understood immediately according to the letter, then it can well, in the character of a miracle, become an object of faith in authority; but [37] how will it fare with personal appropriation? “Are not all these who speak Galileans? And how then do we each hear them in our own tongue, in which we were born? Parthians and Medes and Elamites, and we who dwell in Mesopotamia and Judaea and Cappadocia, Pontus and Asia, in Phrygia and Pamphylia, Egypt and the parts of Libya about Cyrene, and we Romans sojourning here, Jews and proselytes, Cretans and Arabians—we hear them speak in our tongues?” (Acts 2:7 ff.) For faith in authority there is no difficulty here at all; God is, after all, almighty and can do everything he will. But for faith as personal appropriation there is a great psychological difficulty here. If God’s spirit, when it will, intervenes in the life of the soul in so supernatural a way that suddenly, without any preparation, it imparts to consciousness a facility in foreign languages, then the miracle of inspiration stands on the same level as the miracle of Balaam’s ass. The same spirit that can, by supernatural influence, make

a human soul speak a foreign language previously unknown to it can also make an animal soul speak human language. But what then is the nature of the soul, and where are we with our rational consciousness? A real miracle cannot be comprehended, that is true; but if it is not to stand before us as something wildly foreign, something that does not concern us at all, then at least its possibility must be recognized, and the recognition of this possibility must be grounded in self-knowledge.

If we begin from the rational, then one of two assumptions is possible: either the order of nature must have its original ground in nature itself, or in a divine willing. If one assumes the first, then there is no revelation; the doctrine of revelation is mythology. If one assumes the second, then it must be more closely settled what is to [38] be understood by a divine willing. One can then set the divine willing in so necessary a unity with the laws of the sequence of natural phenomena that it wills nothing and can will nothing except what agrees with our rational insight into the connection of the whole and can be incorporated into the ever-widening circles of our experience: from this rationalist standpoint, too, there can then be no question of any special revelation of God.

If the possibility of a revelation is to be recognized, then the divine willing must be expressly placed in a divine will, an almighty, self-determining freedom, and the moving ground of this freedom in an infinite love. This conception must renounce scientific proof, but it is not on that account contrary to reason. No human reason can measure the depths in the disposition of nature, for no human reason can measure the depths of divine love. Natural causes rest on natural dispositions, natural dispositions on divine self-determining; actual nature is a manifestation of the will of spirit. Torn loose from spirit, nature has no independence. The natural causes of natural things are all grounded in the supernatural: the material actuality of nature consists in being the possibility of the supernatural working of the divine will.

Seen from this standpoint, the universe with its laws can be said to rest on a wonder. The creating spirit has not spent its freedom on the order of natural necessity, nor exhausted the inner depth of its being in the outer world of the universe. If the creating, sustaining will is a will of love that will reveal itself, then the possibility of [39] a personal revelation of love must belong from the beginning to the disposition of nature. The wonder of revelation, with its miracles, is from this side to be conceived as a sign of God's personal freedom: in the outworking of the omnipotence of love, the supernatural hidden in nature steps forth from its hiddenness and shows itself in the natural; something new appears in nature, but the order of nature is not broken.

What, now, stands in the way of reconciling faith in revelation with a rational cognition of the world? Among other things, two! In the first place, the modern fixed idea that natural laws, natural dispositions and natural causes cannot possibly have anything to do with the supernatural. That this fixed idea is unreasonable has been shown in what we have said before. In the second place: the sudden, surprising and, for just that reason, improbable character of the phenomenon of revelation as it is presented to faith in authority. But to put the improbable on a level with the impossible is unreasonable. As regards genius, for example, no sharp boundary lines can be drawn between what, by organic disposition, is owed to the activity of the brain, what is owed to self-activity, and what is owed to inspiration. If it is so with the inspiration of genius, how can one demand that in the miracle of inspiration a critical boundary should let itself be drawn between what is personally imparted by God's spirit and what lies beforehand in the human soul? On the other hand, it is an inescapable demand of reason, as regards miraculous as well as inspired genius, that the laws of nature and of spirit, if in highly different ways, must find their fulfillment in both.

[40] This casts a new light on the miracle of revelation and its appropriation. In antiquity the impression of the supernatural was strong, but the development of reason comparatively slight; in our day rational insight into the connection of natural things is rich and clear, but the impression of the supernatural poor, weak and vanishing. If it is to be possible for the consciousness of the present age to bring about a psychological equilibrium between the religious and the rational, it can happen only through an interaction between faith in authority and personally free appropriation.

The word of revelation, with its wonders and holy facts, must, despite the dissolutions of scientific criticism, remain standing for the religious consciousness, unchanged, unchallenged. Reason must regard the holy pictures of life as original paintings by old masters and not allow the colors to be smudged and the features effaced by rationalist fingers. Scientific authority these pictures do not have; but authority of faith, authority of revelation, they have and will have until the end of the world.

The authority of faith, too, must be dissolved; but, be it noted, through a criticism of faith, into self-understanding and personal appropriation. The way in which the dissolution takes place, the depth at which the appropriation proceeds, differs in proportion to the individuals' constitution of mind and the stage of formation at which they stand.

As regards constitution of mind, there are souls of noble nature and rich gifts whose religious need is so slight that they have no sense for a personal spirit, but instead an original, living sense for the impersonal universal, so ingenious a sympathy with the all-life in nature that we must, in a special sense, call them nature-souls. The [41] English poet Shelley, Byron's friend, was such a nature-soul. In his famous Ode to the West Wind he breathes out the need and longing of his being. "O, lift me as a wave, a leaf, a cloud! I fall upon the thorns of life, I bleed. A weight of heavy hours has chained and bowed one who was all too like you—untamable and swift-footed and proud. Make me your lyre, as the forest is; what harm is it that my leaves fall like its own! The might of your tumultuous harmonies will wrest from us both a deep autumnal tone, sweet though sorrowful. Be you, O free spirit, my spirit; be me, you violently storming one! Drive my thoughts, when I am dead, over the universe like withered leaves, that they may call new growth to life, and, conjured by this poem, scatter my words among mankind like ashes and sparks from an unextinguished hearth!" —Again, there are souls in whom the sense for inwardness is so strong, the drive of self-preservation so ideal, the need for knowledge so deep, that they find rest only when they have reached the stronghold of all-love and feel themselves rooted in the eternal ground of the self-thought. These spirited souls of light will not fly off with the storm and be dissolved in the night of the elements; they will be citizens of the kingdom of spirit and freedom. They are not Aeolian harps that sound at the breath of the winds; they are instruments of selfhood, tuned in joy and sorrow for holy harmonies, organs of will for the self-conscious power that makes the storms its angels and the flames of fire its ministers.

Which of the two kinds of soul, now, are the genuine, original human souls? That cannot be settled in rational psychology; it is a faith that must be tested in life.

If we take into consideration the various stages of development and formation at [42] which individuals within the circle of faith in revelation can stand, the conception of what has been handed down will change with each stage, and the religious consciousness will change color. The faith of the child, the faith of the common people and the faith reflected in reason point to different stages of development, and yet faith must be the same in spirit and essence. For the educational system, and especially for those who are appointed to be the teachers of youth, there are serious difficulties to overcome here, psychological knots so intricate that spiritual formation is needed to be able to untie them.

With the faith of the child it seems to go as of itself. The child's soul is just as

receptive to impressions from the supersensible as from the sensible world. The wonderful vividness of the word of the Bible appeals to its feeling and imagination, and the supernatural arouses no offense: heaven is open, and God's angels ascend and descend upon the Son of Man. But as childhood passes and the understanding develops, the crisis sets in.—Let us, to make it vivid, picture to ourselves a half-grown child and his teacher of religion reading together in the Bible: of creation, Paradise and the Fall in the Old Testament, of Christ's birth, his suffering, death and resurrection in the New. Here it must of course be presupposed that the teacher believes sincerely in what is being read about, and that the child is awake and well gifted. Until the young pupil has reached his fourteenth year or thereabouts, everything goes well. The boy takes pleasure in it and understands it all so well, both the part about creation and the part about our first parents, how beautiful it was in the Garden of Eden, [43] and how grateful they ought to have been, but that the serpent led them astray into disobedience; it is almost as if he had lived through it himself. And now the Gospel: the child in the manger, the angels' song of praise, the shepherds' adoration! The childlike pupil understands it, loves it and believes it as surely as if he had seen it with his own eyes. With the earnestness of sorrow, in anguish of heart and grief, he follows the suffering Savior over the brook Kidron to Gethsemane, to Caiaphas, to Pilate's judgment hall; he lives through the crucifixion, he stands among the pious women under the cross. The Savior dies; in the child's soul it is as solemnly still as at the altar in a church. Then comes the morning of the resurrection. The darkness vanishes, the guard flees, the angel, clothed in light and lightning, rolls the stone away from the tomb.

With all this a change takes place little by little. The young pupil also receives other instruction. As a pupil in a grammar school or a modern school he acquires the first elements of science and makes good progress, for he is gifted, has a ready grasp and a naturally sharp understanding. He is now in his fifteenth year. The impressions from his actual surroundings begin to gather themselves for him into a whole world that is highly unlike the one he has received from the doctrine of revelation; the thoughts of culture press in on him; he has secret doubts and does not rightly know how. Meanwhile he is inwardly so taken up with learning and remembering, and outwardly so immediately present among his companions, that he has not yet had time to brood over the connection; but in the religion lesson he has an objection at every moment, which bobs up with an involuntary urge to ask. If the teaching is conducted quite officially, he will take good care not to come out with what is his

own; the explanations he has been taught are more than enough to put down all timid [44] objections. But if he has confidence in his teacher of religion and is so fortunately placed that he can talk with him in all confidence, then misgivings, if in all unclarity, will steal forth. Here is a turning point, where it is to be shown whether the teacher is equal to his task.

If the teacher is a believer of the child's faith who, when it comes to the point, knows no other way out than to appeal to the congregation and the covenant of baptism and the disposition of the heart and the spirit in the child's faith, then he may well, by the warmth of his words and his heartfelt admonitions, make an impression on the young man, perhaps even for a time seemingly lull his mind to rest; but the essence of reason he does not see through, the principles of science he does not grasp: how then is he to be able to help? A seed of doubt has fallen into the young soul, and doubt shoots up and branches out, for doubt has aerial roots like the mangrove, which forms the impenetrable forests in tropical regions.

If the teacher is a high-church orthodox dogmatician, he will take the matter in another way. "Reason is blind to the holy; the heathenishly puffed-up sciences of the present age are all on the way of error. God's revealed word is to be believed literally. When it stands expressly in Holy Scripture that God created the world in six days, then he created it in six days, and what then do the objections of reasoning reason and the teasings of the naturalists signify? God must surely know best himself how long he took to create the world. God's word is infallible as God's spirit is; had creation gone otherwise than it stands written, God's spirit would surely have told [45] us so plainly; for God is truthful, God's holy spirit cannot lie. If heaven were not a fixed vault, how could it stand in so many places that heaven opened? Where then would Christ have gone when he went up to heaven? How could Paul be caught up into the third heaven if there were not three heavens?"—But what is achieved by such arguments other than that the young man now really begins to feel himself a critic? The teacher can impress him with a forceful: "Be quiet and learn your lessons; you are still too green to dispute about such things!" The teacher can let him understand that he has a thorough theologian before him, and give him hope that he himself may one day in time become a thorough theologian and strike all the "rudiments" of physics to the ground; but what does it help the poor pupil? The doubts creep into hiding, but they sit in there.

If the teacher is a genial mixture of critic and theologian, half a rationalist and half an orthodox, he will perhaps initiate the boy into great secrets. He will regretfully

concede to him that things are not quite as right with Holy Scripture and our symbolic books as one might wish. He will, with his hand on his heart, sincerely confess that there are miracles in the New as well as in the Old Testament in which one cannot believe at all: the miracle of the Gadarenes' swine, the miracle of Balaam's ass, and many more. But withal he will then not neglect to impress earnestly on his pupil that there really are also miracles in which one ought unconditionally to believe—with [46] qualification, that is. The miracle of Pentecost, for example, is a principal miracle. There is something grandly symbolic in it; that one must absolutely believe, so as not to become a free thinker. To strengthen the young man at one and the same time in criticism and in faith, the genial teacher will probably also be so kind as to initiate him little by little into the "critical introduction" and into "apologetics." But what will be the consequence? That the man-to-be, if with awakened sense he keeps his sharp understanding unclipped, must end as a "free thinker." If he will let his understanding be circumscribed, that is another matter; then he may perhaps manage to become a theologian.

If the teacher is a man of spiritual formation, a personality who in the fierce currents of the cultural consciousness has worked his way forward, not to a sham child's faith with which one creeps back into the nursery, but to a truly childlike faith, a faith purified in self-understanding, a living faith in the revealed word, then he will know how to take the matter as it is. He will neither rebuff the young man's doubt nor enter into dispute about particulars; he will understand that it is once again the two views of the world, that of antiquity and that of the present age, that of revelation and that of reason, which now begin to wrestle with each other in this soul. Like an experienced pilot he will help the one still inexperienced over the first dangerous shoals, show him the seamarks and orient him on the open sea. It is a psychological crisis he has before him, and he will treat it with the superiority of the mature man.—"What is the matter, my young friend, that you can no longer, as before, believe in the wonder of creation, in Paradise and the Fall, but are even beginning to doubt Christ's resurrection and ascension? A couple of years ago we could both [47] believe in them. I have not changed in this respect. I still find the words of the Bible so telling, its expressions so striking, its images so fresh, so full of life and power, that I am rejuvenated by them and each time appropriate something new. It was the same with you. I still see the tear that broke forth from you when, at the place in the story of the Passion where Pilate says to the Jews: behold *what a man!* you gave vent to your heart and burst out: Had He with the crown of thorns not come into the line of

kings, how detestable the long history of those with the crowns of gold would be! That was a moment when you suddenly seemed to grow older than yourself in being made young. But now you are beginning to grow old; what has happened to you, let me hear!”

The young man takes courage and comes out with his confessions. One day—he relates—we had physics in class; the teacher had grown warm over the proofs of the law of gravity. It is, he said, a law so necessarily grounded in the nature of bodies, so rational and eternal, that no power either in heaven or on earth is able to suspend it. Then one of my companions takes it into his head to ask whether Christ’s ascension did not make an exception. The teacher was silent, but with such a *look* and such an upturned glance that the whole class laughed. I laughed too, although it was like a knife thrust in my heart. This knife thrust gave my understanding a strange sharpness; it was as if it all at once became angry and keen and wanted to cut my faith to pieces. I now began to think over what I had read and heard about our planetary system and our planet’s insignificance in the universe, about the animals of the primeval world and the millions, billions of years that must have elapsed before man appeared [48] on the earth. I am only a beginner, and much of it is obscure to me; but I have an uncanny presentiment, a secret suspicion, that Darwin’s doctrine of man’s descent from some form of ape or other might well be the right one after all. The apes have four hands, man only two; how probable is it not, then, that the hind hands have been transformed into feet in the course of time. Holy Scripture knows nothing of such things. The other day our teacher of natural history drew our attention to the fact that no serpent eats dust, although the opposite—he added with a sarcastic smile—does indeed stand in the Bible. I sometimes feel as though I must either give up science or become a free thinker; the first I cannot do, and the last I should be very loath to do. Every time I come to think of it I feel very unhappy.

If you find yourself unhappy, the teacher answers, then the danger is not so great after all. I was only afraid that you had become a free-and-easy fellow and, in faith in the authority of opinion, had already chosen the modern knowledge of the modern consciousness, as one chooses a modern hat or a modern dress in a fashion boutique. You want to pursue science, and in that you do right; for God has given you abilities and gifts. The deeper you penetrate into the spirit of knowledge and science, the greater respect you will have for such men as Kepler and Newton, Laplace and Darwin; but you will also admire the honesty with which such men always distinguish between what they know and what they do not know. When

- you have come so far, you will bethink yourself that a double limit is set to human knowledge: a relative one, which can constantly be overstepped, and an absolute one, which cannot be overstepped. If your teacher of physics once, at a public examination, set you a problem from higher mathematics that had been solved by Laplace, and demanded that you, without special preliminary study, solve it with the help of your elementary school knowledge alone, would you then regard this as a proof that the teacher himself is a great mathematician, or would you not much rather regard it as an arbitrary and unfair demand? Surely you will not suppose that the teacher who keeps to the simpler problems, and in solving them uses a manner of presentation that those not yet advanced can understand, always does so because he himself knows no more; you will be modest enough to suppose that he may well have a higher knowledge although he condescends to your grasp. Now apply this to Holy Scripture, and ask yourself whether it can be regarded as a proof of the divine spirit's ignorance in physics and natural history that in its revelations about the origin of the world and the descent of the human race it has condescended to the grasp of antiquity and spoken in a language that men could understand. Your sound understanding will tell you that what would be an unpardonable error in a textbook of natural science can be a great merit in a religious communication, where the natural is and remains always a symbol of the spiritual. You speak of becoming a free thinker. If to free thought from ingrown prejudices and preconceived opinions is the mark, then He who says: "You shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free," is the greatest free thinker.
- [49] But if the game of letting one's thought go up in the air, as a boy lets his kite go up in the air, and flutter in every wind, is to mean the freeing of thought, then the free thinker is no more at home in science than in religion. However loosely his thought flutters, it is nevertheless not free; he has a string on it, as the boy on his kite: it has secret orders to peck at what he does not like and to tear down what goes against his instincts. In this sense, I hope, you will never become a free thinker. If you love freedom—I mean freedom of the spirit—then you cannot possibly suppose that true freedom should consist in making spirit the slave of nature and laying it in the chains of necessity. The God of revelation is the God of freedom; what do you think becomes of the freedom of the man who denies the God of freedom and deifies necessity? It looks grand that a man of free thought dares to go round in a ring with the elements and free himself, almost as grand as that a dwarf dares to creep into a giant's armor, and a Tom Thumb to fraternize with Titans. If you love freedom, then the God of freedom is, after all, personally your God, a God who is not outside you but in you as
- [50]

the author of your being, and this God is spirit. Believe in the spirit of freedom, of personality and of love, and the spirit will free you both from unbelief's insult to the supernatural and from superstition's contempt for the natural. Your doubt and unrest mean that you have already set foot on the way of liberation; let me give you for the way the words of Paul: "When I was a child, I spoke as a child, I thought as a child, I judged as a child; but when I became a man, I put away childish things."

We have dwelt so long on this transition because for our educational system it [51] is, at the present time, the most important of all. Could we see the millions of souls who, although they received religious impressions in childhood, have nevertheless since, amid the multiplicity of experiences in the natural world, lost the original, the first simple thing—whether, for the rest, they imagine that they have kept "the child's faith" in the immediacy of authority, or have chosen emancipation with "the gospel of the flesh," or, in indifferentist torpor, neither—could we see them in a psychological mirror, would it not then appear that the incipient corruption stems from the period of transition in which the child ripens into a youth and the youth into a man, precisely the period when religious instruction is concluded? To begin a religious instruction is comparatively an easy matter—any catechism parson and child-believing infant-school Peter can do that; but to bring upbringing to such a conclusion that a religious-personal self-knowledge, in union with a truly rational cognition of the world, can be said to have been founded is a difficult task, whose solution is conditioned by spiritual formation.

Fourth Lecture.

[52] It was in November 1842 that the pseudonym Victor Eremita's *Either/Or* struck into our literature like a bolt from a clear sky. This stroke of lightning can truly be said to mark a turning point in the development of the life of the spirit in Denmark. The very first lines of the preface are characteristic. "It may at times have occurred to you, dear reader, to doubt a little the correctness of the familiar philosophical proposition that the outer is the inner, the inner the outer. You yourself have perhaps kept a secret which you felt, in its joy or in its pain, was too dear to you for you to be able to initiate others into it. Your life has perhaps brought you into contact with people of whom you suspected that something of the sort was the case, without your power or your allurements being able to bring the hidden into the open. Perhaps none of these cases fits you and your life, and yet you are not unacquainted with that doubt; now and then it has hovered past your thought like a fleeting figure."—There is something spectral in this address that heightens expectation. The hermit with the fine, wise

[53] face and the wonderfully clear, penetrating eyes seems to stand before one large as life, with a riddle on his lips, a strange discovery, and to open a secret hiding place. The voice is foreign and yet familiar, not loud but attractive, sympathetic; it caresses the thought, it captures attention, it whispers that there is something within the soul which is called *inwardness*.

The year after, another pseudonym appeared, Johannes de silentio, with *Fear and Trembling*. He foresees his fate in an age when one "has struck out passion in order to serve science." "Love," he says, "has after all its priests in the poets, and at times one hears a voice that knows how to keep it in honor; but of faith not a word is heard; who speaks to the honor of this passion? Philosophy goes further. Theology sits rouged at the window and courts its favor, offers its loveliness for sale to philosophy." One notices from the pseudonym's mood that the passion of faith has brought his mind to a lyrical boil. The year after, a third pseudonym came forward, Johannes Climacus, with the philosophical question: How far can the truth be learned? Here, he says, one meets the difficulty to which Socrates in the *Meno* draws attention as "a contentious proposition": that a man cannot possibly seek what he knows, and just as impossibly seek what he does not know; for what he knows he cannot seek, since he knows it, and what he does not know he cannot seek, for he does not even know what he is to seek.—Everyone will understand that by this pointing to Kierkegaard's

pseudonyms the whole of S. Kierkegaard's literary activity is meant, and that what we in this connection lay weight upon, as regards spiritual formation, must be his peculiar conception of faith and knowledge, religion and reason, Christianity and civilization. [54]

The last part of *Either/Or* closes, as is well known, with "the upbuilding that lies in the thought that against God we are always in the wrong." Our life brings us into a manifold relation to other people. Some of these love right and justice; others do not, they do wrong. "Your soul is not hardened against the suffering they thus inflict on you, but you search and test yourself, you assure yourself that you are in the right, and you rest calmly strong in this conviction; however much they offend me, you say, this peace they shall not be able to rob me of, that I know I am in the right and that I suffer wrong." Our life brings us into a manifold relation to other people; to some we are drawn with a more inward love than to others. "Now if such a person, who was the object of your love, did you wrong, is it not true that it would pain you, that you would carefully test everything, but that you would then say: I know in myself that I am in the right; this thought shall calm me? Oh, if you loved him, it would not calm you; you would search out everything,... you would wish that you might be in the wrong, you would seek to see whether you could not find something that could speak in his defense, and if you did not find it, you would first find rest in the thought that you were in the wrong."

It is otherwise with our relation to God, for it is a relation of infinity. Only in an infinite relation to God can doubt be set at rest; only in an infinitely free relation to God can man's anxiety be transformed into joy. "In an infinite relation to God he is when he recognizes that God is always in the right; in an infinitely free relation, [55] when he recognizes that he himself is always in the wrong. So then doubt is halted; for the movement of doubt lay precisely in this, that at one moment he was to be in the right, at the next in the wrong, to a certain degree in the right, to a certain degree in the wrong, and this was to designate his relation to God; but such a relation to God is no relation, and this was the nourishment of doubt.... And should the thought that against God we are always in the wrong not be inspiring, for what does it express but that God's love is always greater than our love?" It fills a person's soul with strength to act, it makes him fervent in spirit; only when he calculates finitely is the fire of the spirit put out. "Even if you yourself were the one who had to deny yourself your highest wish, you are nonetheless glad; you do not say God is always in the right, for in that there is no jubilation; you say: against God I am always in the

wrong. If what was your wish was what others and you yourself in a certain sense must call your duty; if you had not only to deny your wish but in a way to betray your duty; if you lost not only your joy but even your honor, you are nonetheless glad; against God, you say, I am always in the wrong. If you knocked but it was not opened; if you sought but did not find; if you labored but received nothing; if you planted and watered but saw no blessing; if heaven was shut and the testimony failed to come—you are nonetheless glad in your work; if the punishment that the fathers' brothers had called down came upon you, you are nonetheless glad, for against God we are always in the wrong.”—This is the wonder of faith, the tongue of inspiration, the proclamation of the ideal in the direction of inwardness.

In “Fear and Trembling” Abraham is presented as the father of faith; the point is [56] the sacrifice of Isaac. The poetic gift with which the presentation is endowed will always be an object of aesthetic admiration, and the dialectical sharpness with which “the absurd” in faith is driven to a higher madness will for a long time to come give matter for religious reflections and ethical discussions. “They rode in silence for 3 days; on the morning of the 4th day Abraham still said not a word, but lifted up his eyes and saw Mount Moriah in the distance. He left the young men behind and went on alone with Isaac by the hand up the mountain. But Abraham said to himself: ‘I will not, after all, hide from Isaac where this way is leading him.’ He stood still, he laid his hand on Isaac’s head in blessing, and Isaac bowed to receive it. And Abraham’s countenance was fatherliness, his gaze was mild, his speech admonishing. But Isaac could not understand him; his soul could not be lifted up; he clasped Abraham’s knees, he pleaded at his feet, he begged for his young life, for his fair hope; he recalled the joy in Abraham’s house, he recalled the sorrow and the loneliness. Then Abraham raised the boy up and walked with him by his hand, and his words were full of comfort and admonition. But Isaac could not understand him. He climbed Mount Moriah, but Isaac did not understand him. Then he turned away from him for a moment, but when Isaac saw Abraham’s face the second time, it was changed; his gaze was wild, his form was terror. He seized Isaac by the breast, threw him to the ground and said: ‘Stupid boy, do you think I am your father? I am an idolater. Do you think it is God’s command? No, it is my desire.’ Then Isaac trembled and cried out in his anguish: [57] ‘God in heaven, have mercy on me; God of Abraham, have mercy on me; if I have no father on earth, then be you my father.’ But Abraham said softly to himself: ‘Lord in heaven, I thank you; it is better after all that he believes I am a monster than that he should lose faith in you!’ ”—That is one possibility of mood in “Fear and Trembling.”

Yes—one will perhaps say—deep and dark are the depths of the sea, but deeper and darker still are the abysses of the mind that open when faith conjures in uncomprehended passion, and melancholy and eccentricity and strange fancy keep one another company to accompany Abraham to Mount Moriah and stare him in the eye just as he draws the knife. Abraham stands as a venerable figure wrapped in the mists of antiquity; the great features stand out clearly in the holy legend so long as he is seen at a distance; but if one ventures to approach the place of sacrifice and make his act present to oneself, then the understanding is lost, the riddle of revelation, the terrible absurdity of faith, confounds its thoughts. This misgiving is, however, as regards the essence of faith, at least provisionally removed by the fact that the author has drawn for us another exemplar, a figure as if taken out of the present age, a knight of faith, at one and the same time hero and philistine. “Here he is. The acquaintance is made, I am introduced to him. The moment I first set eyes on him, I instantly thrust him from me, myself jump back, clap my hands together and say half aloud: ‘Good Lord! is this the man, is it really he? he looks just like a tax collector.’ Yet it is he after all. I draw a little closer to him, watch the least movement, to see whether there might not show itself a little heterogeneous fragment of telegraphy from the infinite, a glance, a [58] look, a gesture, a sadness, a smile, that betrayed the infinite in its heterogeneity with the finite. No! I examine his figure from top to toe, to see whether there might not be a crack through which the infinite peeped out. No! He is solid through and through. His footing? It is vigorous, belongs wholly to finitude; no spruced-up townsman who goes out to Frederiksberg on a Sunday afternoon treads the ground more firmly; he belongs wholly to the world; no philistine can belong to it more. Nothing is to be discovered of that foreign and distinguished nature by which one recognizes the knight of infinity. He takes delight in everything, takes part in everything, and every time one sees him take part in something particular, it is done with a persistence that marks the earthly man whose soul clings to such things. He attends to his work. When one sees him then, one would think he was a clerk who had lost his soul in Italian double-entry bookkeeping, so punctual is he. He takes a holiday on Sundays. He goes to church. No secret glance or any sign of the incommensurable betrays him; if one did not know him, it would be impossible to pick him out from the rest of the crowd; for his sound, vigorous singing of the hymns proves at most that he has a good chest. In the afternoon he goes out to the woods. He delights in everything he sees, in the throng of people, the new omnibuses, the Sound—when one meets him on the Strandvej, one would think he was a shopkeeper’s soul out on a spree, just so

does he enjoy himself; for he is not a poet, and I have in vain tried to spy out in him
 [59] the poetic incommensurability. Toward evening he goes home; his gait is as untiring as a postman's. On the way he thinks that his wife surely has a special little hot dish for him when he comes home, for example a roast head of lamb with vegetables. If he met a kindred spirit, he could go on all the way to the East Gate conversing with him about this dish with a passion befitting a restaurateur. As it happens, he does not own 4 shillings, and yet he firmly believes that his wife has that delicious dish for him. If she has it, it would be an enviable sight for distinguished people, and an inspiring one for the common man, to see him eat; for his appetite is stronger than Esau's. His wife does not have it—strangely enough—he is exactly the same. On the way he passes a building site; he meets another man. They talk together for a moment; in an instant he erects a building; he has all the powers needed for it at his disposal. The stranger leaves him with the thought that he was surely a capitalist, while my admired knight thinks: yes, if it came to that, I could easily get it. He lies at an open window and looks at the square on which he lives, at everything that goes on: that a rat slips under a gutter plank, that the children play; everything occupies him with a calm in existence as if he were a girl of 16. And yet he is not a genius; for I have in vain tried to spy out the incommensurability of genius in him. He smokes his pipe in the evening; when one sees him, one would swear it was the grocer across the street vegetating in the twilight. He lets things take their course with an insouciance as if he were a frivolous good-for-nothing, and yet every moment he lives he buys the
 [60] opportune time at the dearest price, for he does not do even the least thing except by virtue of the absurd."

The question of the absurd thus becomes, in the very highest sense, a question of spirit, indeed a question of blessedness. In the "Concluding Unscientific Postscript to the Philosophical Crumbs," Johannes Climacus presents the problem thus: "The individual's eternal blessedness is decided in time through the relation to something historical, which is furthermore historical in such a way that there is included in its composition that which by its essence cannot become historical, and so must become so by virtue of the absurd." What this means is shown vividly, from an exclusively Christian standpoint on an evangelical-historical foundation, by Anti-Climacus: "*Practice in Christianity*." The absurd, which to faith is a blessedness, is to unbelief an offense. Christ, the object of faith, is the possibility of offense: "1) the possibility of offense that does not relate to Christ (the God-man) but to him as a quite simply individual man who collides with the established order. 2) The essential

possibility of offense in the direction of loftiness, that an individual man speaks or acts as if he were God, says that he himself is God, and so in the direction of the determination God in the composite God-man. 3) The essential possibility of offense in the direction of lowliness, that he who gives himself out to be God shows himself to be the lowly, poor, suffering, finally powerless man.”

With this the standard that had hitherto held was annulled, and the staff broken over the many learned, half-historical and half-philosophical attempts to make Christianity comprehensible to human reason. Historical investigations into the genuineness of the Bible, dogmatic speculations about the Church’s teaching and the like, may well furnish suitable entertainment for the learned themselves, but for faith they mean nothing. Faith is an offense to the understanding and foolishness to reason; the believer believes the absurd: faith is a paradox. How, then, are we to come to faith? By the way of inwardness under the pressure of temporality, in the tribulations of finitude. “Imagine, hidden in a simple setting, a secret compartment in which the most precious treasure is deposited;—there is a spring that must be pressed, but the spring is hidden, and the pressure must have a certain force, so that an accidental pressure cannot be enough: so is the disposition to faith, the hope of eternity, hidden in man’s inner being, and tribulation is the pressure. When the hidden spring is pressed, and the pressure is strong enough, then the content opens in all its glory. Or imagine a creeping animal that nevertheless has wings, which it can use when it is driven to extremity, but for daily use it does not find it worth the trouble to use them: so is the disposition to faith, the hope of eternity, in man’s inmost being: he has wings, but he must be brought to extremity in order to discover them, or to get them and use them.” [61]

By presenting faith as paradox, S. Kierkegaard gave the reasoning understanding, with its self-important doubting of everything, a slap in the mouth. With the paradox as presupposition he developed, in “Works of Love,” in “The Sickness unto Death” and in his many upbuilding discourses, a complete cycle of religious categories, contour lines of ideal circles, sound figures of a resounding eternity.—One would have thought that a proclaimer of Christianity of such superior gifts must have found support [62] among all the teachers of Christianity, the scholarly as well as the popular. But no! The theologians looked with secret horror on the strange phenomenon, and there came over them a feeling, an uncanny presentiment, that here was something with which things did not hang together right. “What, then? Surely there could never be anything wrong with theology? Might it perhaps have to fear a fire?” Where are you

going? Theology has nothing to fear; its clay is fireproof, its stronghold is secure. The outhouses with sheep and cattle and other livestock are, besides, insured. No, it is the poor author who, with all his wit, his cleverness and his dialectic, is losing his mind. That is a pity; otherwise one could have used him—not for church history, for he lacks the learning and the grand overview for that; not for dogmatics, for he lacks the speculative profundity and the sense for the objective for that; but for apologetics: he could have won himself a name as a Christian apologist. Now he must be given up.—And so the watchword went out from headquarters that the whole extensive Kierkegaardian literature was, until further notice, to be treated as a heap of “stray thoughts, aphorisms, notions and flashes.”

One would have expected that the clergy, the proclaimers of the word in the congregation, would have made use of a helping hand by which they could all at once be rid of the rationalist nuisance and have the authority of the Bible, unclipped, for reliable use. But no! There must be measure in all things. If the word of the Bible is to be really upbuilding, it must be kept in a certain twilight of pastness. It does no
 [63] harm that there is a little uncertainty in the background, a little fear of free thinking in people’s minds; the proclaimer of the word then has the advantage of being able to strengthen his hearers in the faith and to speak an authoritative word of warning against “the unbelief of these times.” For S. Kierkegaard, general reflections on “those times” and “these times” were idle dawdling. Anyone who will can become, in the spiritual sense, contemporary with Christ in the same way as the apostles. For about Christ, objectively seen, one gets to know nothing. Christ is the object neither of pious admiration nor of criticizing curiosity. Christ is the sign of contradiction, the possibility of offense, faith’s only-begotten. Christianity is not a doctrine; it is an “existence-communication.” Will you exist as a Christian or will you not? That is the question. If you will not, you can go your way; if you will—see, here is the pattern! So he held the New Testament so close before the eyes of priest and congregation that with his “contemporaneity” he became really somewhat intrusive. He was answered in the name of the Church that, as regards existence, there was nothing amiss. “We have the same Lord, the same faith, the same baptism, the same Holy Spirit as the apostles. True, we cannot do such mighty works as the apostles, nor live as economically as the apostles, for the times have changed; but we rely securely on the Lord’s word: Thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it.”—Now the fortress was invested, and the bombardment began.

“Imagine that there was a mighty spirit who had promised some people his

protection, but on the condition that they should present themselves at a certain place to which it was dangerous to go—suppose now that these people failed to [64] present themselves at the appointed place, but went about at home in their living room speaking inspired words with one another about how the spirit had promised them his mighty protection, so that no one should be able to harm them: is this not ludicrous?... That the gates of hell shall not prevail against his church—these words of Christ have lately been brought to mind again and again against me, against my assertion that Christianity does not exist at all. My answer is this. That promise does not help us in the very least; for the twaddle we live in, as if it were being a Christian, is not at all what Christ and the New Testament understand by being a Christian. Christendom is not at all the church of Christ; nor do I say that the gates of hell have prevailed against the church of Christ, by no means. No, I say that ‘Christendom’ is a twaddle that has clung fast to Christianity like a cobweb on a fruit, and that is now so kind as to want to mistake itself for Christianity.”

We strive and struggle, we yearn and seek. What is it we seek? “First the Kingdom of God.” (A Sort of Short Story.) Ludvig From, candidate in theology—he is seeking. And when one hears that a “theological” candidate is seeking, one needs no lively imagination to understand what it is he seeks: naturally the Kingdom of God, which one is, after all, to seek first.—No, it is not that after all; what he seeks is a royal living as a priest; and, as I shall indicate with a few strokes, a very great deal has first happened before he has got that far. First he went to grammar school, from which he was then sent up to the university. Then he first took 2 examinations and, after 4 [65] years of study, first took his degree examination. He is then a candidate in theology; and one might perhaps think that, after first having got through all this, he can at last come to work for Christianity. Yes, on the guild’s terms. No, first he must spend ½ year at the seminary; and when that is over, there can be no question of being able to apply during the first 8 years, which must thus first be got through. And now we stand at the beginning of the story: the 8 years have elapsed; he is applying. His life, which hitherto cannot be said to have had any relation to the unconditioned, suddenly takes on such a relation: he seeks unconditionally everything; he writes one sheet of stamped paper full after another, runs from Herod to Pilate, commends himself both to the minister and to the porter; in short, he is wholly in the service of an unconditioned. Indeed, one of his acquaintances who has not seen him for the last couple of years thinks, to his astonishment, that he discovers that he has grown smaller, which can perhaps be explained by its having gone with him as with

Münchhausen's dog, which was a greyhound but from all the running became a badger. So 3 years pass. Our theological candidate really needs rest, needs, after so enormously strenuous an activity, to be put out of activity, or to come to rest in an office and be cared for a little by his future wife—for he has meanwhile first become engaged. At last—as Pernille says to Magdelone—the hour of his “redemption” strikes, so that with the whole might of conviction he will be able, from his own experience, to “witness” to the congregation that in Christianity there is salvation and redemption: he gets a living. What happens? On obtaining still more precise [66] information than he has hitherto had about the income of the living, he discovers that it is about 150 rix-dollars less than he had thought. Now all hell is loose. The unhappy man almost despairs. He has already bought stamped paper to submit a petition to the minister that he be permitted to be regarded as not called—and so to begin again from the beginning: when one of his acquaintances gets him to give this up. So it rests there; he keeps the living. He is ordained—and the Sunday has come when he is to be presented to the congregation. The rural dean by whom this is done is a more than ordinary man; he has not only (what most priests have, and as a rule in a degree the greater the higher they rise in rank) an unclouded eye for earthly profit, but also a speculative eye on world history, something he does not keep to himself but lets the congregation benefit from. He has, ingeniously, chosen as his text the words of the apostle Peter: “Behold, we have forsaken all things and followed thee,” and now explains to the congregation that precisely in times like ours such men are needed as teachers, and in connection with this he commends this young man, of whom the dean knows how near he came to withdrawing for the sake of the 150 rix-dollars.—The young man now himself mounts the pulpit, and the gospel of the day is (strangely enough!): Seek **first** the Kingdom of God. He preaches his sermon. “A very good sermon,” says the bishop, who was himself present, “a very good sermon; and it produced a real effect, the whole passage about ‘first’ the Kingdom of God, the way in which he emphasized this ‘first.’” “But does Your Reverence think, then, that [67] there was the desirable agreement here between the speech and the life? On me it made an almost satirical impression, this ‘first.’” “What an absurdity; he is, after all, called to proclaim the doctrine, the sound, unadulterated doctrine of seeking first the Kingdom of God; and that he did very well.”

By looking away from life and talking about the doctrine, the sound, unadulterated doctrine, one obtains “new-fashioned religious safeguards.” “Once, in a long, long vanished time, people understood the matter thus: it was demanded of him who

would be a teacher of Christianity that his life afford the guarantee for what he taught. One has now long since got away from this; the world has become wiser, more earnest, has learned to despise all this pettiness and morbidity about the personal, has learned to covet the objective alone—now it is demanded that the teacher's life afford the guarantee that what he says is commerce, dramatic festivity, divertissement, purely objective. Some examples. Is it this you will talk about, that Christianity, the Christianity of the New Testament, has a predilection for the single state—and you yourself are a single man: my dear man, that is nothing for you to talk about; the congregation might think it was earnest, become uneasy, or it might feel offended that you so unbecomingly mix your personality in. No, it will be a long while yet before you can become fit to talk about it in earnest in such a way that you truly satisfy the congregation. Wait until you have once already got your first wife in the ground and are well along with the second: then the time has come for you; then you step forward before the congregation, teach and “witness” that Christianity has a predilection for the single state—and you will satisfy completely; for your life affords [68] the guarantee that it is nonsense, commerce, or that what you say is: interesting.—Is it this Christian thing you will talk about, that Christianity teaches contempt for titles and orders and all the fooleries of honor—and you yourself are neither a person of rank nor anything resembling it: my dear man, that is nothing for you to talk about; the congregation might think it was earnest, or feel offended by the lack of formation in thus forcing your personality upon it. No, wait until you have first got yourself a heap of orders, the more the better; wait until you yourself drag a string of titles about with you, so that for the number of titles you hardly know yourself what your name is; then the time has come, then you step forward, preach and “witness”—and you will undoubtedly satisfy the congregation; for your life affords the guarantee that it is dramatic entertainment, an interesting forenoon diversion. Is it this you will talk about, that to proclaim Christianity in poverty is the true Christian proclamation—and you yourself are literally a poor devil: my dear man, that is nothing for you to talk about; the congregation might think it was earnest, become frightened, feel altogether out of humor and be in the very highest degree uncomfortably affected by poverty coming so close to one's life. No, first get yourself a fat living, and when you have had it so long that you will soon advance to a still fatter one: then the opportune time has come; then you step forward before the congregation, preach and “witness”—and you will satisfy completely; for your life affords the guarantee that the whole thing comes to a jest, such as earnest men may wish for, in the theater or in church, a refreshment

[69] for gathering new strength to—make money.—And that is the way God is worshipped in the churches! And then these velvet and silk orators weep; the voice fails, choked in tears!”

It is told in the Gospel that an angel at certain times went down into the pool of Bethesda and troubled the waters, so that whoever among the many sick first stepped into the bath thereafter was healed. Here too is one who troubles the waters, the waters of faith, of thought and of language; but is he an angel? He seems rather to be a demon; for anyone at all among “the healthy” who ventures a leap into the troubled waters must surely become lame in both soul and body. What, then, is he, what does he want? “What I want? Quite simply: I want honesty. I am not, as people with good intentions have wanted to present me—for the view of me taken by embitterment and rage and impotence and twaddle I cannot take into account—I am not a Christian severity over against a given Christian leniency. By no means; I am neither leniency nor severity—I am a human honesty.”

The highest question of spirit and of culture has been set in motion. Who is right, then, S. Kierkegaard or his opponents? The question goes deep, and is moreover so sharpened and pointed that it sets its spear point against the breast of the age and forces it to stand before an Either/Or. One can turn one’s eyes away from the question and act as if it were forgotten or did not exist at all. But it exists all the same, and will not be turned away. When one reads the collected newspaper articles, Kierkegaard’s attack and the clergy’s defense, and takes “the Moments” along with them, there [70] takes shape out of the proceedings a peculiar picture, a situation that recalls the hero and the chorus in ancient tragedy. This drama in our Danish literature will surely pass into foreign literatures and be performed on the great stage of the world. In a hundred years the lover of the paradox, with his works of love and his “1000 priests,” will stride across the stage, dramatically and with full music, like Don Juan with his 3000 mistresses.

Fifth Lecture.

The Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists. That is S. Kierkegaard's [71] assertion, his "only thesis." And the proof? It is short and pithy. Christianity is "existence-communication." Religious existence in the present age and religious existence in the time of the apostles are so diametrically opposed to each other that the one can be regarded as a parody of the other. "If what we understand by being a Christian really is being a Christian, what then is God in heaven? He is the most ludicrous being who has ever lived, his word the most ludicrous book that has ever seen the light: to set heaven and earth in motion (as he does in his word), to threaten with hell, with eternal punishments—in order to attain what we understand by being Christians (and we are, after all, true Christians): no, anything so ludicrous has never occurred! Imagine that a man came up to a person with a loaded pistol and said to him: I will shoot you down; or imagine, what is still more terrible, that he said: I will seize your person and torture you to death by the most horrible manner of death if you do not (now pay attention, here it comes!)—if you do not make your life here on earth as profitable and as full of enjoyment as is possible for you: then this would [72] surely be the most ludicrous speech. . . . The most horrible kind of blasphemy is the one 'Christendom' is guilty of: to transform the God of spirit into—a ludicrous piece of twaddle; and the most spiritless kind of worship of God, more spiritless than anything that is or was found in paganism, more spiritless than worshipping a stone, an ox, an insect as God, more spiritless than everything, is: to worship under the name of God—a twaddle-head!"

When did the Christianity of the New Testament cease to exist? As people gradually ceased to renounce the world, to sacrifice life for the faith and to suffer for the doctrine. It still existed, then, in the time of John Huss; Luther, too, must surely be counted among the Christians of the New Testament? Yes, in a way; but if we take it strictly, Christianity has not really come into the world at all. It stopped with the pattern and at most the apostles; but these already proclaimed it so strongly in the direction of propagation that here already the trouble begins. . . . Only divine authority could so impress the human race that it became an unconditioned earnest to will the eternal unconditionally. Only the God-man would be able to endure, if one will think of it, to work unconditionally through 1000 years and again 1000 years for the propagation of the doctrine by proclaiming it, even if he did not get a single disciple, if he could

get them only by altering the condition. The apostle, after all, has some selfish need of the relief of getting followers, which the God-man does not have, who does not selfishly need followers and therefore has only the price of eternity, no market price.”

[73] *And whose, then, is the fault that the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists?* Men’s fault, naturally. “In the New Testament, according to Christ’s own teaching, being a Christian is, humanly speaking, sheer torment, a torment compared with which all human sufferings are almost only childish pranks. What Christ speaks of—for he makes no secret of it—is crucifying the flesh, hating oneself,... the most heartrending sufferings in hating father, mother, wife, one’s own child”... That was not at all to men’s liking. So they resorted “to hypocrisy, they falsified the definition of being a Christian. Being a Christian, it was said, is sheer blessedness: ‘what were I, oh, what were I, if I were not a Christian; oh, inestimable good to be a Christian; yes, being a Christian is what first gives life real meaning, its joys their savor and its sufferings their relief.’ ”

Here is S. Kierkegaard’s *manifest self-contradiction*.

First he defines Christianity as an existence-communication, a supernatural communication of spirit, a gift of God’s free grace, and makes the expression more precise to the effect that Christ, the God-man himself, the only true man of spirit, is the only true Christian. The apostles, his nearest followers, already betray, despite inspiration, on the very feast of Pentecost, a dubious inclination to falsification, a “selfish need of the relief of getting many followers.” And why? Because the spirit in the apostles was not as strong as the spirit in Christ. So unconditionally is the existence-communication dependent on the supernatural, paradoxical-miraculous communication of spirit that the utmost exertion of human power and will in this relation becomes a vanishing [74] quantity. A person can and should appropriate the divine in so far as it is personally communicated to him, the single individual; but no person can with all his zeal add one cubit to his stature, or appropriate even the least of what is God’s, if God himself will not communicate it to him. On this presupposition, then, S. Kierkegaard with his “human honesty” should have come to the following result: the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists. Alas, how regrettable. But let us not lament over it or make ourselves fruitless reproaches; for it is not men’s fault but God’s inscrutable will. In the fullness of time God made an experiment with a supernatural existence-communication, but let it drop again shortly afterwards. How? For what reasons? Did his love grow cold, did the spirit grow tired, did men make things so hard for him that he grew weary of the whole thing? Ask not, mock not! It is, after all,

what it is meant to be—a paradox, an absurdity. With this explanation the spokesman of the paradox could boldly have maintained his thesis and consistently have finished with what he calls “the twaddle of priests.”

But that was not the way he went. He took another run at it. He set forth the pattern in order to enforce the demand for unconditional imitation. Anyone who earnestly wills must be able to believe that the God-man has existed. In faith in this existence the existence-communication, with its supernatural conditions, is given once for all. Every believer who wills can become contemporary with Christ, can step into his footprints and follow after him. “The relation is: the more you have to do with God, and the more he loves you, the more, humanly speaking, will you become [75] unhappy for this life, the more will you come to suffer in this life.” The supernatural, paradoxical-miraculous existence-communication is now made dependent on man’s mind and will to such a degree that there is not even a shadow of change on God’s side, for God is love and in the moment has to do with everyone who will have to do with him. The thesis put forward must then be defended thus: the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists; but it is not God’s fault, it is men’s fault. “This I know from experience in two ways. Partly from the fact that I cannot bear the thought” (the thought of love) “and therefore merely, as one who discovers, catch sight of this true Christian definition of being a Christian, while for my own part I help myself to endure sufferings with a far lighter thought, a Jewish one, not a Christian one in the highest sense: that I suffer for my sins; partly from the fact that through the circumstances of my own life I had to be led to become aware of this”.... The “human honesty” is now this: the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists; for I, Søren Aaby Kierkegaard, have not willed that it should exist. Had I willed to have more deeply to do with the divine love and let it make me absolutely unhappy, wholly and altogether unhappy in this life, then there would at least have been one Christian: Christianity would then have existed in me. But as it is, I have not willed it. Why not? Mock not, ask not about it; it is, after all, what it is meant to be: the paradoxical, the absurd. My task I have accomplished: to tear the mask off hypocrisy. The priests say that they will what Christ wills, and to keep people in this illusion [76] they put on devout faces and falsify Christianity; I state truly what Christianity is, and then I anoint my head and wash my face and say freely: Christianity does not exist at all; I am not yet a Christian, because I do not yet will to be one. That is my honesty toward the priests.

One sees that the last explanation does not fall short of the first in effrontery and

madness. Of such effrontery S. Kierkegaard has certainly not made himself guilty. But by what has he avoided the extremity of madness? By swerving from consistency, putting a button on the spear point and confessing his frailty: I cannot bear the great thought of Christ; the pattern is too great and I am too small; in other words: I am still waiting for an existence-communication.

The Kierkegaardian relation to God is worlds apart from the relation to God of the New Testament. The relation to God of the New Testament is an immediate relation of revelation; the Kierkegaardian one is an infinitely dialectical relation of reflection. The contradiction, the radical self-contradiction, which S. Kierkegaard with all his reflecting never brought up into consciousness, is this: that a derived relation of reflection to God should be able to give the same existence as the primitive relation of revelation. Certainly S. Kierkegaard thought and acted, lived and suffered second to none in his age. His nearest posterity has not yet properly bethought itself what work of the spirit he has accomplished, and how infinitely much it owes him. But his reflection was negative; the paradox, the absurd, was his only positive. The positive of the paradox—that is its deep secret—is itself, in its inmost being, negative.

[77] The blessed intoxication in suffering, renunciation, sacrifice is a negative existence; God's love dissolves into sheer negative determinations and is transformed at last into a soul-devouring depth of the abyss that is more terrible than death. "God is your mortal enemy; he, love, he will out of love for you be loved by you: this means that you must die, die away, otherwise you cannot love him. So there he sits, omnipresent and omniscient as he is, and watches you, knows even the least thing that goes on in you—that he knows, your mortal enemy! Beware of wishing for anything, beware of fearing anything; for what you wish is not fulfilled, but rather the opposite, and what you fear, the more you fear it, the sooner it comes upon you. For he loves you, and he will be loved by you; both out of love; but as soon as there is something you wish, you are not thinking of him, just as when there is something you fear; or if you bring him into connection with your wishing and fearing, then you are, after all, not thinking of him in and for himself, that is, you do not love him—and he will be loved, wills it out of love."—With such a love one lands not in heaven with Christ but in Nirvana with Buddha.

As the revelation of truth that opens the holy springs of life, Christianity can with reason be called an existence-communication, in so far as it is an infinitely fruitful communication of life. But life and existence are not, after all, synonymous words. The same life can express itself in different existences: eternal life is the inexhaustible

ground of temporal existences. The eternal life in the essence of Christianity does not stop at the stereotyped scheme of existence of a single age; it enters, unchangeable as [78] it is, into changes; eternal as it is, into time and vicissitude; supernatural as it is, into natural conditions and natural relations; blessed as it is, into earthly corruptibility, into the unrest, sufferings and strife of worldly conflicts. Hereby the relation between communication and appropriation is to be more closely determined. Here there is a continued interaction between communication and appropriation, but the factors of the interaction do not always stand in the same relation.

At first the divine factor is almighty and overreaching. The Word becomes flesh; the revealer of God steps forth as man, teaches and suffers, dies and rises again in attestation of the personal victory of life over death. He enters into glory; but just as he has taken his seat on the throne at the right hand of the Father, the spirit comes down upon the apostles as in a rushing mighty wind with tongues of fire, and the fire kindles in these witnesses, and the tongues glow in the flames of testimony. That was the great time of breakthrough; heaven was opened and the graves were opened: the hidden wonder broke out, in this working of the spirit, in manifest miracles.

Such is the primitive existence-communication, the Christian existence in the New Testament. To measure the existence of the present age by this standard, and to make "Christendom" answerable for having lost the New Testament existence by its own fault, betrays an enormous misunderstanding. The apostolic existence ceased when the period of breakthrough was concluded.

There now follow periods in which the divine communication withdraws in the form of the hidden wonder, so that the human factor of appropriation may [79] come forward in particular and arrive at conscious activity—the Catholic and the old Protestant period.

If we look away from the differences in externals and fix our gaze on the essence of appropriation alone, then the Catholic Church, by its holiness of works, has undeniably done everything to exert the human will, but it has also done everything to keep up the illusion of a communication of spirit continuing in miraculous breakthroughs.—The interaction between the divine and the human factor has thereby taken on a stamp of mechanical finitude. The Protestant Church has pushed back the notion of miraculous breakthroughs and reduced the communication of spirit to a quiet, perennial wonder. It has not, indeed, wished to slacken the power of appropriation, but it has nonetheless given the will a one-sidedly inward-turning and self-dissolving direction in the dogma of justification by faith.

Both churches are, each in its own way, in equally great embarrassment with actual human nature and with existence as it works its way forward. And why? Because, robbed of the gushing spring of the spirit that supernaturally nourished the apostolic existence, they have nonetheless held fast to the apostolic scheme of existence in the form of imitation. We are, on the instructions of both, to renounce the world, mortify the flesh, subdue the natural drives—in short, to regard the whole present life as a misery that is good only for tormenting us up to blessedness in the beyond. As regards humane existence, Catholicism, with its thoroughgoing asceticism, its undisguised enmity toward free, rational enlightenment and its monasticism's dark [80] contempt for the natural ends of life, is, however, more consistent than Protestantism. The Protestant Church, while retaining its apostolic scheme, has wanted to adopt humanity and take the beauty of culture into its embrace; that is an ambiguity for which it has had to pay dearly. Where now is the New Testament existence, where is the mortification of the flesh, where is the Kingdom of God? "Ludvig From, candidate in theology, he is seeking."—S. Kierkegaard's satire has a tangible effect; every stroke of his scourge leaves bloody weals, precisely because he makes valid the New Testament scheme of existence, solemnly acknowledged by his opponents themselves.

The existence of the present age has peculiar demands which it neither can nor will give up; it asserts the significance of natural life from the ground up and demands that reason be acknowledged. If Christianity really were a paradox, and faith an absurdity, then the Christianity of the New Testament would certainly no longer exist; but, be it noted, for the reason that it has never existed except in men's imagination, an imagination that can hold out only until the paradox has been discovered.

What is the paradox? The paradox, with the absurd, comes to light when two concepts that, in full transparency, show themselves to be mutually contradictory are put together in unity. A square circle is an absurdity. If one now says: in the highest regions of spirit and truth all circles are square, and this is to be believed against all understanding, then reason protests; we then have the paradox. If one says: in the existence of the God-man something has become historical that by its essence cannot possibly be historical, and so must have become so by virtue of the absurd, and this is [81] to be believed against all understanding, then reason protests: we have the paradox. That the contradiction in the square circle and the alleged contradiction in the essence of the God-man are, however, absolutely heterogeneous contradictions, anyone who will use his reason can see. The concept of the circle and the concept of the square can be made clear in exact determinations and corresponding forms of intuition. But

the content of the concept of God we cannot exhaust in exact determinations, nor that of the concept of man either. When, then, faith holds fast the unity of both concepts in the essence of the God-man, reason grasps that what is thereby presupposed is not an absurdity but a mystery.

Perhaps "From, candidate in theology," will remark that this is just what he has long known from theology, and for just that reason is seeking. . . . Let him seek! The mystery is not an old theological night in which all cats are grey; it is not the indeterminable twilight in which religion is stirred together with science, faith with reason, into edifying explanations for unclear heads. The mystery is a limiting concept in which faith and knowledge meet and part. It must be precisely determined, by careful criticism of knowledge, how deep reason can reach in the cognition of the natural; the absolute limit at which cognition dissolves is the mystery. It must be precisely determined, by careful criticism of faith, how deep the religious consciousness can go in the cognition of the supernatural without coming into contradiction with reason and thereby into conflict with itself; the absolute limit at which it is dissolved is the mystery.

The miracle of revelation is a mystery, the essence of the God-man a mystery. If [82] one now fixes one's attention one-sidedly on the miraculous outbreaks and the corresponding crises of existence, while arbitrarily avoiding thinking of the intermediate determinations hidden in the mystery, one does quite rightly get out of it that the whole is an absurdity. If, with S. Kierkegaard, one applies such a scheme of existence as the standard to the existence of the present age and demands commensurability, one does quite rightly get out of it that faith and Christianity, the acknowledgment of the absurd, the paradoxical, no longer exist. But the mystery of revelation still exists, and will go on existing.

"The ideals must be proclaimed!" Right. But the question is how they are to be realized and take shape as existence. Abraham still stands as an exemplar of faith; but not directly by his scheme of existence. "God tempted Abraham and said" God, then, spoke to Abraham as a master can speak to his servant. This scheme we cannot appropriate. At our stage of existence, anyone who appeals to divine commands by immediate prompting will be regarded as of unsound mind. On the other hand, that a person, after conscientious self-examination and mature deliberation, finds himself on religious grounds obliged before God, absolutely obliged, to sacrifice even what is dearest and most precious to him in the world, cannot be regarded as unsoundness of mind. "God said to Abraham: take Isaac, thine only son, whom thou

lovest, and go... and offer him for a burnt offering"... If this scheme is to hold literally for the present age, then the God of believers becomes a Moloch, and the highest
 [83] existential expression of faith and obedience would then be: to sacrifice one's children to Moloch. On the other hand, a personal demand of the spirit, even if in its inner unconditionedness it must come into strong collision with the notions of the age, may well be conceived to be grounded and fully justified. He who, in fidelity to the will of the spirit, with God alone as his confidant, is to satisfy the demand, will learn what obedience is, what it is to believe and to bear a responsibility. When he then, under the heavy pressure of the heavy responsibility, lifts up his head and sees Abraham standing on Mount Moriah with the sacrificial knife in his hand, then the ideal is drawn on the dark ground of the mystery; he sees a shining, uplifting example of faith and obedience.

"The ideals must be proclaimed!" Yes. But surely not by their being reduced to absurdity. The humorous figure that S. Kierkegaard's pseudonym has formed by fusing knight of faith and philistine is, as drawn, sound to the core; but by the mechanics of the absurd it moves on screws. "He (the knight of faith) drains in the infinite resignation the deep sadness of existence, he knows the blessedness of infinity, he has felt the pain of renouncing everything, the dearest one has in the world, and yet finitude tastes to him just as good as to one who never knew anything higher, for his remaining in finitude has no trace of a cowed, anxious training, and yet he has this security in delighting in it as if it were the most certain thing of all. And yet, yet the whole earthly figure he presents is a new creation by virtue of the absurd. He resigned everything infinitely, and then he grasped everything again by virtue of
 [84] the absurd. He constantly makes the movement of infinity, but he does it with such correctness and assurance that he constantly gets finitude out of it, and there is not a second in which one suspects anything else."

This marvel is now illuminated in particular by means of a young swain who puts the whole content of his life into his love for a princess, although the relation is such that this love "cannot possibly be realized, cannot possibly be translated from ideality into reality." To state exactly where the absurd lies, the knight of infinite resignation is set over against the knight of faith. When the knight of infinity has seen the impossibility of getting the princess, he resigns the fulfillment of his wish. His love takes on a religious character and is transfigured into a love for the eternal being, which indeed denies him the fulfillment but nonetheless reconciles him in the eternal consciousness that he possesses the beloved in a recollection that no actuality

can take from him. He makes the impossible possible by expressing it spiritually, and he expresses it spiritually by renouncing it. The wish, which would have led him out into actuality but was wrecked on the impossibility, is now bent inward, but is not on that account lost, nor forgotten either. From the point where the knight of infinity stops, the knight of faith makes one movement more, more wonderful than everything, for he says: I believe nevertheless that I shall get her, namely by virtue of the absurd, by virtue of the fact that for God all things are possible. Thus the knight of faith is “the only happy one, the heir apparent to the finite,” while the knight of resignation is “a stranger and a foreigner.”

The cardinal point about which the movements turn is the boundary point between the possible and the impossible. Each of the two lovers is agreed with himself that it [85] is, humanly speaking, impossible for him—not merely improbable, in the very highest degree improbable, but absolutely impossible—to get the princess. Let us now look more closely at what this implies. For human understanding to be perfectly certain of the impossibility, it must have an unmistakable sign. What sort of sign would that be? That the royal father, even in full accord with his council of state and the whole diplomatic corps, European, Asian, American and Australian together, set himself against the match would not be the unmistakable sign. The king might, after all, die, and the diplomatic positions change. Even if the princess’s heart were cold to her lover’s pleas, that still would not be the unmistakable sign. It would not, after all, be impossible that her feelings might change; there are examples of young girls who have given up their coyness and at last let themselves be moved. But—let us posit this case—if the princess died: yes, then we have the sign, for it is certainly, humanly speaking, impossible to marry her when she is dead and buried. What does the knight of resignation do now? He resigns infinitely the fulfillment of his wish, but keeps his love in the pain of recollection. But what does the knight of faith do? He gets the—dead and buried—princess, and lives with her in full finitude, in external actuality, in joy and glory, by virtue of the absurd. If this is to be understood literally, then one must undeniably grant the pseudonym is right when he exclaims: “the last astonishes me; my brain turns round in my head at the thought of it. The movement of resignation I make by myself, and what I gain by it is my eternal consciousness in [86] blessed understanding with my love for God. But by faith I renounce nothing; on the contrary, by faith I get everything, precisely in the sense in which it is said that he who has faith as a grain of mustard seed can move mountains.”

Either reason or faith! Where faith begins, reason ceases; i.e., so long as a person

has still kept a little remnant of sound reason, infinite resignation is his highest; he reaches only the point where faith should begin. The believer has put the whole stretch of reason behind him and goes further. For him the boundary between probable and improbable, possible and impossible, no longer exists, for with God, after all, all things are possible. So: either reason, and then without any faith, or faith, and then without any reason; this is the Kierkegaardian dilemma. But if we look more closely, might it not then appear that faith and reason, although in the human sense two absolutely heterogeneous factors of cognition, nevertheless have their ground of unity in the depth of the divine being, in the mystery?

The pseudonym in “Fear and Trembling” assures us that he can make the movement of infinite resignation by himself—without faith—in “blessed understanding” with his love for God. But a blessed understanding with God is impossible when the thought that for God all things are possible is excluded. It is said in “The Sickness unto Death”: God is this, that everything is possible. By denying this thought one abolishes the concept of God and denies God; but a blessed understanding in love for a denied God is an absurdity. If this absurd is absolutely to be the mark of faith, then [87] the knight of infinite resignation already finds himself, in his way, within the domain of faith. The absurd in the knight of faith is to be this: that in the midst of finitude he knows how to come to terms with the difference between what, in the human sense, is possible and what is impossible, between the probable and the improbable, although he nevertheless holds fast to the thought that for God all things are possible. The knight of faith is therefore, in his way, a quite reasonable man. But if the knight of resignation, precisely by being reasonable, is a believer, and the knight of faith, precisely by being a believer, is reasonable, then the boundary is, after all, removed.

Has the opposition in principle between faith and reason vanished, then? By no means! Here the start is made from two absolutely heterogeneous points of departure: the connection of things by natural necessity, and the omnipotence of the divine will; but as one descends into the depth from the one side and ascends out of the depth from the other, it appears that the last and outermost boundary between possible and impossible vanishes in the mystery. The ideal of reason is to bring all the possibilities of actuality under the conditioned necessity of the existence of all things; the ideal of faith is to bring necessity, with the infinite chain of conditions, under the unconditioned freedom of the divine will; but no mortal shall be able to point out the last and outermost boundary where conditioned necessity ceases and absolutely unconditioned freedom begins. The original, actual unity of freedom and

necessity is hidden in the mystery.

In presenting the ideals of faith the Kierkegaardian pseudonyms speak with different tongues and contradict one another most forcefully, precisely by virtue of the absurd. In Johannes de silentio the absurdity of faith makes the believer the patriarch of the promises, the heir of the blessings, the heir apparent to the finite, the most blissful man on earth: Abraham gets Isaac by virtue of the absurd; the knight of faith gets the princess—the princess dead and buried for the sake of impossibility—he really gets her; they live together in joy and gladness, by virtue of the absurd. But in Johannes Climacus and in Anti-Climacus it goes otherwise. In Climacus, faith causes the reflecting humorist, who would so gladly understand it and enter into it, the most dreadful troubles of existence, by virtue of the absurd; and in Anti-Climacus, the religious character who is and lives in the midst of faith, faith makes man, humanly speaking, the unhappiest of creatures, precisely by virtue of the absurd. But when the absurd is just as potent to make a person happy as to make him unhappy, how can the difference between the happy and the unhappy become the gauge of the strength of faith? [88]

The existence-scheme of sufferings, pains and renunciations can in principle be just as misleading as that of joys and enjoyments. Christ did not come into the world to intensify sufferings or to heighten joys; that he nonetheless does both means that he came in the absolute sense, for the sake of life and light and truth, for the revelation of God's secret counsel, from the holy depth of freedom, the mystery of righteousness and love.

It is quite another thing when the educative element is spoken of. From the standpoint of upbringing and spiritual development, S. Kierkegaard has unmistakably grasped what is right, in so far as, in his proclamation of the ideals, he has again and again, with the penetrating sharpness of a psychological observer and the convincing power of a painful experience of himself, enjoined voluntary obedience under the law of the spirit and preached "the gospel of sufferings." But the existence of the present age and its spiritual conditions he did not understand. He thought to overawe the established order by bringing forward the New Testament demands of existence and, with colors of glowing spirit, burning every feature of the scheme of the great breakthrough into the consciousness of his contemporaries; and he did not notice that his age, however run down it was by its "new-fashioned religious safeguards," was nevertheless right against him on one very essential point. He thought to bring about a spiritual revolution, a decisive catastrophe. Even on his deathbed he is said to have [89]

said: "I fall like a bomb, the bomb bursts, and then it catches fire." But the commotion passed, and the catastrophe failed to come; the bomb burst, but nothing caught fire. On the other hand, he undeniably succeeded, in a quite striking and conspicuous manner, in surprising and catching the whole official church establishment in the consequences of its own presuppositions.

The single individual is not to have the right to mock the congregation and put his subjective reflection in the place of the communication of spirit; but let it only be said straight out: there is in the official proclamation of Christianity something that must be changed from the ground up. It is not the revealed word that is to be changed; it is the appropriation, the free, personal appropriation of the rich truth, that must be presented in a new light. If the thought of Christ is to take root in souls [90] and become the deepest, most powerfully moving thought of life in the age of culture, then the images of the child's faith and the notions of the faith of the common people will not suffice. It is a real understanding of the compatibility of the religious with the rational on which everything above all depends. The transformation of existence is not catastrophic; it takes place—given an exertion of will—from within, slowly and quietly, but surely and soundly, through upbringing and progressing spiritual formation.

Sixth Lecture.

The existence of the present age has its own character; in bearing, gait and physiognomy it distinguishes itself clearly and definitely from all its predecessors. Its way of seeing is realistic; it keeps to the actual as it stands and goes. Yet it by no means intends thereby to deny spirit or to despise ideal demands; but it has a suspicion of all abstract, high-flown ideals, whether they put on religious, ethical, political or aesthetic forms. Ideals in the blue may be as lovely as they like; they are nonetheless barren clouds, airy vegetations that cannot thrive in the soil of actuality; they work harm when, in the name of eternity, they suck the blood of temporality and drain the marrow from the present life instead of giving it strength. The existence of the present age is by no means without conscience, nor does it exactly suffer from scruples: its conscience is like a fetus that has turned in the womb. [91]

That human nature, on account of its doubleness (dualism) as sensible and spiritual, constantly gives the impression that man lives as a frontier soldier between two realms, a natural and a supernatural, is a fact. The opposition between the spiritual and the bodily, the heavenly and the earthly, will not let itself be effaced, however much one strives, for the sake of harmony and unity, to weaken and suppress the one member. [92] The naturalistic endeavor, to glorify nature at the expense of spirit, and the ascetic one, to help spirit to victory by killing nature, are corresponding extremes. Neither of these extremes is able to beguile the present age. The consciousness of the present age has criticism enough to see that a naturalistic morality is not only just as hollow as asceticism, but, in all its parading of the glory of sensuous life, still more contemptible.

The ascetic, in the midst of his error, nevertheless has an unconditional acknowledgment of spirit as the highest. His conception of the essence of spirit may be poor and unclear; but once he has recognized that spirit is will, he does not spare himself, but summons up everything to obey the command of the spirit and satisfy its demands; he mortifies his flesh, he stifles the natural lusts, he hardens his will by refining it in the fire of the pains of renunciation. One may deplore his one-sidedness; but one cannot deny him a certain esteem.

The naturalist, with "the autonomy of the drives" and "the gospel of the flesh," seeks his point of support in "the modern consciousness." He can with a certain right appeal to the fact that natural life is the foundation of the life of the spirit, but he distorts the truth by reducing the alleged life of the spirit to a formal reflected gleam

of the consciousness of the essence and working of natural, finite, corruptible life. He can make a good deal of fuss over the works of the spirit that have already been accomplished and are yet to be accomplished in the future before the ideal comes
 [93] into its own and the work of freedom is completed. But if we look more closely, the whole thing comes down to a denial of the absolutely self-valid will of spirit, and so of spirit as spirit. The divided forces of will are transformed into elementary forces of nature. The great drama that the conflicts of these natural forces, necessary by reason, produce receives its spirited stamp by being beheld, criticized and enjoyed by “the modern consciousness.” The highest task of mankind, the depth in all its longings, the reward of all its efforts, the goal of its strife and striving, must then be placed in raising itself up to the standpoint of “the modern consciousness.” What the Church was for the believers of the Middle Ages, “the modern consciousness” is for the knowers of the present age. The Church gave indulgence for all manner of sins and even winked at gross excesses, provided only that one condition was present: faith in the Church and in the infallibility of its authority. If this condition was not present, then woe to the offender; even if his life had the purity of the angels and all the good works of a saint, he was nonetheless a heretic, excommunicated and condemned to eternal perdition. The critical majesty of “the modern consciousness” has stepped into the place of the Church. Thought is free—that is to say, when it submits unconditionally to the infallibility of “the modern consciousness”; for this infallibility is not merely an article of knowledge, it is an article of faith. The devotees of science may have conflicting views, doubt reason, deify reason, and make themselves guilty even of gross inconsistencies: no matter! Criticism gives indulgence for all manner of contradictions and winks at the frailty of thoughts, even at gross
 [94] *inconsistencies*, yet, be it noted, on one condition: that their authors sincerely profess “the modern consciousness.” If this condition is lacking, the guilty one may pack up and hang himself on the tree of knowledge. The heretic is condemned—not to stake and fire, for “the modern consciousness” holds to what is humane—but to be expelled from science, robbed of the future and set in the pillory of literature, for a terror and a warning to others.

The consciousness of the present age, seen in its essence, by no means coincides with “the modern consciousness.” The knowers of the present age know very well how to distinguish between the passing and the abiding. Truth is neither old-fashioned nor modern; it is eternal. The eternal truth can change form and expression as the times change, but in essence and ground it always remains the same.

The spirit of personal truth that reveals itself in religion can, at the stage of the consciousness of the present age, be recognized in two mutually corresponding forms of activity: the original form of communication and the derived form of appropriation, the first characteristic of the existence of breakthrough, the second decisive for the existence of the present age. Never before in history has the opposition between the two forms of existence stood out so clearly. The relation has hitherto been more or less obscured by the fact that one has partly wished to arrange the derived in the likeness of the original, partly to give the derived the appearance of being the original itself in its further continuation, and partly, finally, to remold the original by accommodating it to the derived. Catholicism furnishes telling examples of attempts in the first two directions. Apostolic holiness, apostolic miracles repeat themselves in deceptive imitations; even the Savior's life and holy wounds are copied in medieval color [95] prints. The old Protestantism let the original stand as the perfect, the unattainable, and contented itself with appropriating the doctrine, without being able to come to clarity about the transformation of existence. While in actuality it entered upon an accommodation to the changed conditions of the times and gave full acknowledgment to the authority of the state and the manifold demands of civil society, it nevertheless felt itself obliged in conscience to enjoin the literal observance of the apostolic precepts, without daring to admit to itself that the latter stood in glaring contradiction to the former. Only in the period of the Enlightenment did people begin to take courage. By the light of reason they saw how unreasonable it was to live directly by the apostles' instructions. But what did they do then? They made the apostles into "reasonable" men, gave their words a "reasonable" meaning, and drew a plain bourgeois morality out of their teaching. The alleged "perfectibility" of Christianity had the consequence that the derived was put in the place of the original: the copy became the original, and the original the copy. The rationalist blunder was, however, too obvious to hold its ground in the long run. The apostolic existence has stepped forth again in all its peculiarity, and the question is how the existence of the present age is to arrange itself so that the derived may, in spirit and in truth, correspond to the original.

The first thing needful is that the opposition come out into full light. The existence of revelation, with its ideal marks of character, remains standing unchallenged. Over against this authority the existence of the present age takes its stand on its historically determined foundation, with clear consciousness of its peculiar spiritual conditions. [96] The existence of the present age knows in itself that it neither can nor will set itself up to be a direct imitation of that ideal existence of breakthrough. The ideal existence

commends, for example, the single state; but the existence of the present age maintains that marriage and family life can, in the name of the spirit, be just as justified as celibacy. When the ideal existence prefers poverty to wealth, the existence of the present age is of the opinion that one can prefer wealth to poverty without offending the ideal. When the ideal existence of breakthrough looks down on political conditions of society as on something indifferent in itself, and regards being a slave as just as favorable a condition as being free, then the existence of the present age declares straight out that the political condition is by no means indifferent, that there must be fighting, in the power of the spirit, for civil order and civil freedom, and that esteem and honor are better than lowliness and dishonor.

What the present age thus declares is the sincere conviction of its heart. By showing itself as it is and speaking its mind straight out, the existence of the present age places itself in a truer relation to the holy authority than by flattering and dissembling. Nothing can be more odious to the spirit of truth than hypocrisy; the divine majesty is not accessible to devout compliments.

It might indeed seem as though the existence of the present age, by declaring itself in a direction so opposed to the ideal existence, meant to defy authority and withdraw from the demands of the spirit. That is a great misunderstanding. The meaning is that the two forms of existence, the ideal existence with its original and the [97] real existence with its derived, must come out into full opposition, so that their unity may be recognized in its depth and the bond of the spirit between them be tied all the more firmly. What separates the existence of the present age from the first original is something more than “the unbelief of the world” and “the ungodliness of these times”; it is something over which the human will has no arbitrary command. That breakthrough of the spirit did not, after all, take place on account of men’s holiness; rather, the spirit broke through in order to sanctify men. The apostles were, by their own confession, sinners, and the members of the apostolic congregation were great sinners.

It is on the communication of spirit and the corresponding historical conditions that the opposition essentially rests. In the existence of breakthrough the self-communication of the divine spirit was so mightily overflowing that it drove its chosen ones forward to voluntary testimony, strife and struggle for the kingdom of light and truth. Over against this kingdom of light and truth stood the kingdom of the world, the kingdom of darkness and falsehood, which had to be fought with spiritual weapons. What was hostile to spirit was external; suffering and tribulation, and

indeed discord within man himself, were conditioned in particular by this externality: the spirit was willing, though the flesh was weak. In the existence of the present age the communication of spirit is weaker, not a miracle manifest in visible outbreaks but a quiet, perennial wonder. The abrupt, catastrophic transitions from darkness to light, from unbelief to faith, that characterize the period of breakthrough have been transformed into gradual, step-by-step transformations, conditioned by the strength of the will in the labor of appropriation. In the time of the apostles it was the spirit that in a supernatural manner seized human souls, filled them, lifted them, raised them above time and corruptibility. In the present age, conversely, it is men who must [98] seek the spirit present in its means of salvation, seize it, hold it fast, and by inward appropriation work their way up through the entanglements of temporality to truth and eternal life. The swift movement from above downward has been converted into a slow movement from below upward.

The kingdom of the spirit, which in the language of revelation is called the Kingdom of God, is called in the language of the present age the kingdom of humanity. Now if it could be shown that the Kingdom of God was too narrow to embrace everything that belongs to the truly human in its full extent, or if it could be established that the kingdom of humanity had a foundation of its own on which it could be built, fortified and extended without the help of the Kingdom of God, then the humane and the religious would certainly fall apart. If the humane really fell outside the religious, then it would be quite in order that the two realms of the spirit should go on fighting each other to the death, for the complete victory of the one would necessarily be the downfall of the other. But it appears, on the contrary, that both realms, originally seen, have the same foundation, the same highest end, so that no one can enjoy full citizenship in the one without being a citizen of the other; here there are not two realms but two forms of existence of one and the same divine-human kingdom of the spirit.

When it nevertheless looks as though there really were two realms here fighting each other, this cannot be ascribed to the constituting fundamental law; it must be the fault of the citizens, who, by clinging one-sidedly either to the one or to the other of the two forms of existence, fall into discord with one another, form parties and plague [99] the realm with internal disturbances. Let us try to illustrate this by some examples.

The laws of the spirit. By taking his stand exclusively on the side of the Kingdom of God and speaking the language of revelation, the preacher of repentance gains the authority to assert the unconditional validity of the holy laws. They are, after all,

not commandments of men but commandments of God. God himself has expressly given these laws; the description of the divine legislation makes an imposing effect. Jehovah thunders from Sinai, and the mountain trembles, and the consciences of the hearers tremble: these are the commandments of the Almighty; woe to him who dares to transgress them!—The history of the Pietists and the Methodists furnishes telling examples of what stirrings of the spirit the preaching of repentance is still able to call forth in recent times. A holy authority is needed to awaken the natural man to earnest self-examination. There is something awakening in severity itself: the faith of the common people is rejuvenated and strengthened by it; the commanding words work on the mind uplifting like voices from on high, refreshing like breaths of divine majesty. But, remarkably enough, such preaching makes as good as no impression on the man of culture. Taking his stand exclusively on the standpoint of humanity, he regards the whole machinery of supernatural driving wheels as an apparatus of motion that human imagination, without rightly knowing it, has itself constructed. The effect the machinery has on believing souls is naturally an object of his observing attention; but it is only an object. It lightens from the gloom of the clouds, from the dark wings on which the spirit hovers, but the lightnings do not strike the humane observer; he stands calmly under the thunder of Sinai, unperturbed, like a correspondent reporting to his newspaper.

And what, then, comes to stand in the newspaper? “It is a sign of the times, a remarkable phenomenon, to see the eloquent N. N., glowing with inspiration, gather the masses in crowds about his pulpit. A grand awakening! His speech is a cloudburst; the words fall like raindrops, refreshing after a long drought.” Then follows the description of a remarkable man with a high forehead, sparkling eyes, sunken cheeks, thin lips and a long beard. Looks, gestures, turns of phrase and catchwords are pointed out most exactly, but of the spiritual in the matter itself not a word is reported.

That God himself should have dictated the ten commandments of the law of Moses will be found, on behalf of humanity, still more unreasonable than that he should have dictated how many and how long curtains were to be hung in the tabernacle, of what colors and with how many loops. The humanists, who see so clearly that there is a difference between moral commandments and crimson curtains, also see that the difference consists precisely in this: that the moral commandments must have what curtains can hardly have, an unmistakable stamp of the necessity of reason, of universal validity. It might indeed, on a preliminary consideration, seem as if it were less needful that God himself should give revelations about the curtains than that he

should reveal the moral laws; but from a humanist point of view the matter appears the other way round. About veils, curtains, lamp oil and the like Jehovah necessarily had to give word-for-word instructions if he wanted the tabernacle arranged exactly after his own head, for such specialities, which cannot possibly be derived from pure reason, must for that very reason be reckoned to the inventory of “the Kingdom of God.” As regards the moral laws, on the other hand, a miraculous revelation is altogether superfluous, for these laws have their sufficient ground in reason and in human nature, and belong expressly to the kingdom of humanity. [101]

So sharply can the exclusively religious and the exclusively humane stand against each other. But that the religious, by one-sidedly holding fast to the supernatural, just as surely misunderstand religion as the humane, by one-sidedly keeping to the natural, misunderstand humanity, can be clearly shown.

Religious awakenings have at all times the great significance that the truly awakened will grasp the matter from the ground up, put the original into force and penetrate to the core of the life of the spirit. But the limit and barrier is that, with all their zeal for the right of the spirit and the holy laws, they never get as far as any real account of the natural laws of actual life, of men’s laboring, working and striving in the present. They constantly stop at the explanation that it is an evil, ungodly, sinful, vain and corruptible world in which we live. They can count off on their fingers the many transgressions, sins and dissipations to which the children of the world are given. But what do they put in their place? A system of holiness that consists in making life as sour for oneself as possible. It is not enough to keep the ten commandments; there are many other commandments to keep: God’s children must not, e.g., laugh, smoke tobacco, dance, play cards, go to the theater, etc. By banishing the enjoyments of life and setting narrow limits to what is permitted, one aims at securing for the spirit a lasting dominion over the flesh; and it is certain that, if it were only a question of a life with fewer and fewer pleasures, the brothers and sisters of the strict discipline would stand on a superior level. But the false presupposition that spirit and nature stand hostile to each other shines through. So long as it has not been seen on the religious side that the spiritual needs the natural, that it is the goal of the spirit to refine the natural, to develop, form and further human life in all directions, so long will the proclamation of the Kingdom of God be powerless in the face of humanity, without essential influence on the existence of the present age as a whole. [102]

At the stage of humanity the trouble is of the opposite kind. Here the start is made without further ado with the natural, the present, the manifold tasks of actual

life. Then the point is to show the laws. But what sort of laws are they? Sheer natural laws—valid for the animal as well as for man. In human life these laws are now, so far as the activity of the brain permits, to be transformed by degrees into general laws of reason and thereby into laws of the spirit. But the transformation goes only slowly. Pure reason with its categorical imperative is an abstraction, and nature rebels against all abstractions. Actual reason lies hidden in the actual drives. The actual drives are not only selfish but also sympathetic. In the mutual helpfulness of the baboons the moral essence of humanity is prefigured. In man—especially through the hereditary improvement of the brain—empirical ideas become little by little a priori. Under the continued interaction of the manifold forces of society, the moral

[103] drives pass imperceptibly over into moral principles, into a system of moral laws. The moral laws form the foundation of humanity and the humane spirit. Trade, industry, economy, capital, politics, science, poetry and art labor in the service of the spirit; the result of all these labors is the growing power of the human spirit over lower nature. This spirit of humanity has an infinitely long past and an infinitely long future, but, alas, no actual present; for it has never had and will never get any actual unity of will. From the interaction between the single wills of society the unity of will, and with it actual spirit, can never result. The single wills are, in their inmost ground, wills of drive; but when the will of drive is to be the original, then we come—to the baboons.

The exclusively religious go wrong in the absolute; they stop at a supernatural will of God whose unconditional commandments they are unable, in all their obedience, to conceive as proclamations of a will of the spirit that permeates the whole of human life. They cannot satisfy religion because they cannot satisfy humanity. The exclusively humane go wrong in the relative. With their natural wills of drive they are not able to raise the human spirit to actual dominion over the conflicting elements of natural life, and, as a matter of course, not able to satisfy the demands of humanity. Religion demands the humane, for it demands a divine liberation of the powers of human life. Humanity requires the religious, for the exertions of relative wills are in vain if they do not have the holy, absolute will as their bearer and prime mover.

[104] *Justice.* “Tremble, you sinners, for God is just!” When this cry rings out over the world in the name of revelation, it seldom fails of its effect. Just when men are most at odds, they are most of all agreed in complaining of the abomination of wrong, the presumption, violence and arbitrariness of growing injustice. On the religious feeling of the common people that admonishing cry will then work like a stroke of lightning and give consciences a mighty jolt. The believers beat their breasts;

everyone confesses his sin in order to flee from the wrath to come. Behind this momentary penitence there lurks not infrequently a selfish notion that by confessing one's sins one can at once be rid of them, that it is of course not so much oneself as the ungodly world, full of injustice, that must dread the punishment. The judge of the world, the Just One, takes up the cause of the oppressed, the wronged, and everyone, after all, feels himself wronged. "When the Son of Man comes in the clouds with power and great glory, he shall separate the just from the unjust as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats, and then all the kindreds of the earth shall wail; but the elect, who are atoned for by the blood of the Lamb, who have put off their own righteousness and put on the Atoner's, shall be received into grace."

On the man of culture of the present age such a solemn announcement of God's justice will make no impression. Criticism must find that the sharp separation between the just and the unjust is inhumane: there is right and wrong on both sides, on that of the "sheep" as well as that of the "goats." Nor is it correct to say: God is just, for [105] justice is a concept that finds application only to human relations. Even if one will say that justice is divine, it is nonetheless only an abstraction. Pure justice is worth nothing in itself; it is a commemorative coin that is not in circulation. Actual justice exists only in the actual disposition that shows itself in the strife about mine and thine, and so in the way in which one conceives and treats positive questions of right. But the positive questions of right are human questions, and the right of pardon a human right with a smack of arbitrariness, which characterizes finitude and belongs in each and every respect to relativity.

From this standpoint, too, the opposition between the religious and the humane shows itself as an irreconcilable discord. But what is the reason? In the immediately religious notion it looks as if human justice were without validity before God. It can then be said of all appearances of this justice what a Father of the Church has said of the virtues of the heathen: that they are splendid vices. If this is understood to mean that human justice, when, held fast for itself, it will have merit before God, must become an expression of human effrontery, nothing can be objected to it. But when justice is conceived in such a way that this essence must necessarily exclude human nature and put the divine in its place, then the religious is indeed absolutely incompatible with the humane, but then the fundamental religious thought is also obscured. Believers are to appropriate the Atoner's righteousness; but the Atoner makes it manifest precisely that the divine itself is human. If the Atoner is [106] conceived merely as a historical individuality who once suffered and died because

of men's injustice, then it is altogether impossible to appropriate his righteousness. But the essence of the Atoner is, in the divine-human sense, the inmost true essence of mankind. The Atoner came once for all externally to men as a historical figure precisely in order that he may now and henceforth come inwardly in the spirit with his righteousness, not as a foreign person but as the essence and ground in all true human personality. To appropriate the Atoner's righteousness is to deify human justice and to humanize divine justice; it is, in the deepest sense, to satisfy humanity.

If we take our stand on the humane standpoint and begin with the strife about mine and thine, then it is granted, after all, that disputes about rights, even the most zealous, cannot possibly lead to just relations unless they are grounded on the thought of justice and conducted with a just disposition and a just will. If one does not respect the unconditional validity of justice, but makes justice in and for itself an empty concept, then the finite strife about rights will end with the right of the stronger, and relative justice will be transformed into a positive expression of relative injustice. If relative justice is to triumph approximately over injustice, it must happen by virtue of the idea of justice. But the idea of justice is an idea of will; absolute justice presupposes an absolutely just will, a will that in the last instance gets the better of all injustice.

[107] Faith in triumphant justice is inseparable from faith in the God of justice. For the sake of human justice God must be absolutely just: the humane requires the religious.

What is here indicated can be developed infinitely; but the further the development goes, and the more exactly the determinations of the relation are stated, the more clearly it appears that religion must be humane, and humanity religious.

Spiritual formation. If we set the existence of the present age, on its historical foundation, with its labors and ends, freely over against the apostolic existence with its ideal breakthroughs, while yet recognizing both existences as essentially belonging together, then we get an impression of a dualism in the grand style. The servants of the Kingdom of God, with their heavenward direction of life and all-sacrificing renunciation of the world, "by honor and dishonor, by evil report and good report, as deceivers and yet true, as unknown and yet well known, as dying and yet living, as chastened and yet not killed, as sorrowful and yet rejoicing, as poor yet making many rich, as having nothing and yet possessing all things"—and then the servants of humanity, immersed in the earthly, striving for the temporal, laboring for the present, for the demands of the moment in the bondage of finitude, rich and yet poor, surfeited and yet hungry, cheerful and yet in secret anxiety, glad and yet troubled, always troubled about worldly goods, honor, power and civic influence—what an enormous

opposition!

And yet both existences belong to one and the same realm, the kingdom of the spirit; the fundamental law is the same for both, the fundamental law of freedom, justice and love. The unconditional demand is that the spirit shall rule everywhere in its kingdom, in the lower as in the higher regions. Now if the apostolic existence did [108] not stand firm on the holy ground of authority, the testimony to the right and the goal of the spirit would vanish. What the spirit can demand of man when sensuous drive and selfish willfulness rebel against its dominion, what sacrifices it requires, what powers it has, what means it offers when in the strife it comes to the uttermost—all this would be clean forgotten; the holy, the absolutely exalted, which holds the standard, would sink down into sheer finitude, sheer relativity, and false weight and measure would creep in everywhere and confuse humane relations. As little as right and justice can be done in a civil society with false coin, false measure and weight, so little can order be kept in the kingdom of the spirit when the ideal standards are broken, when the higher can become the lower and the lower the higher, as the day by turns raises up and casts down its idols.

The ideal existence holds not only for God's sake but first and last for man's sake, and the present age is so far right when it fixes its gaze on the world of realities and holds to the humane. It is undeniably an illusion, indeed an ingrown prejudice, that the holy God of the spirit should have prescribed to men a single law, a single condition, that was not grounded in the disposition of human nature, not necessary for its free, personal self-development. But that the personal can be grounded on something impersonal is an illusion too.

It is the life of the congregation that continues to form the foundation of the life of the spirit. The servants of the word in the congregation have the great task of upholding and enjoining the conditions of the Kingdom of God, not with an assumed apostolic authority but, for the sake of appropriation, with the whole superiority of [109] spiritual formation. The teachers of youth have the great task, by the means of spiritual formation, of giving the revealed truths a practically intelligible expression in the language of humanity, and of making them present, by the authority of the ideals, in the earnestness of upbringing.—Then there is indeed a difference between the church-school and the culture-school, but the discord is removed, a mutual understanding has been reached, so that both schools, if by different means and along different ways, can work in the same spirit toward the attainment of the same goal.

There are, to be sure, those who think that the time of religion is past, that

humanity alone has the future before it. On their instructions we are not to remain standing on the ground of the Church and stare toward the East with Luther; we are, with a new Columbus, to hoist the swaying flag of “free thought” and boldly steer our course toward the West. “Far in the West, in the Atlantic of the discoveries of nature, lies the promised land of the spirit, hidden like a pearl in the deep.”—That is false guidance. He who blindly plunges into the gulf of naturalism does not come up “with a pearl in his hand,” but—with a bubble in his mouth.

The same spirit of life and truth that once, by extraordinary self-communication, brought forth the apostolic existence still communicates itself, on the humane conditions of appropriation, with the power of rejuvenation and transformation to the existence of the present age. The scheme is different, but the content is the same. The means we have; the conditions are given us; it depends only on our using them rightly. To use them rightly, upbringing and spiritual formation are required.